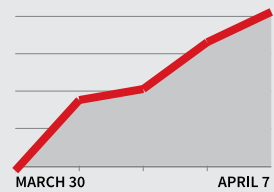


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	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	23123.65	+155.40
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	20.51	+0.14
US Dollar (in ₹)	92.98	-0.08
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	147194.00	-1109
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	230881.00	-3162

TOP HEAD HUNT.

The Air India board has constituted a committee to find a CEO and MD post the resignation of Campbell Wilson **p2**



POLLSCAPE.

From ₹218 crore to just ₹84, stark wealth gap among Kerala Assembly poll candidates **p7**

QUICKLY.

THREE MORE MONTHS

DoT extends Voda-Idea AGR reassessment deadline

New Delhi: The Department of Telecommunications has extended the deadline of adjusted gross revenue (AGR) reassessment for Vodafone-Idea (VIL) by three months to June, sources said on Tuesday. The reassessment was earlier targeted for completion by March 31. **p12**

SKYMET FORECAST

‘South-West monsoon will be below normal’

Chennai: Private weather forecast agency Skymet has predicted a below normal South-West monsoon in view of El Nino emerging later this year. **p10**

₹15,000 CRORE DEAL

Macquarie sells Safeway stake to Vinci Highways

Mumbai: Macquarie Asset Management has announced the sale of its interest in Safeway Concessions to Vinci Highways, a subsidiary of Vinci, at an implied enterprise value of about ₹15,000 crore (around \$1.7 billion). **p2**

Chandra may not seek 3rd term as Tata Sons Chairman

TURBULENCE. Power struggle within Tata Trusts, loss-making bets cloud next term

Janaki Krishnan
Mumbai

Tata Sons Chairman N Chandrasekaran may not offer to helm the conglomerate for a third term, sources said, though he will be drawing up a detailed plan for the future growth trajectory of the group and setting out timelines for loss-making entities within the group to start showing profits.

With several dynamics playing out among the trustees and divided loyalties, the situation has become uncomfortable for Chandra, who has all along been seen as the one stable element among the power shifts within the various factions, said insiders.

UNDER THE LENS

While he is still respected and well regarded, they said the fact that the performance of the group under his watch had come under scrutiny is casting a shadow over his continued presence.

The overall robust performance of the group under



Tata Sons Chairman N Chandrasekaran **ANI**

his tenure has been overshadowed by losses in entities such as Air India, Tata Digital, Tata Projects and Tata Electronics.

The next meeting of Tata Trusts, slated for June, will be crucial as the trustees are set to review the performance roadmap of the group, resources going into the new businesses and the returns, and plan to reduce losses in several of the new ventures and make them profitable.

This also includes Air India, which returned to the Tata fold in 2022 and has been struggling to take off.

Chandra's reappointment next year will also be part of the discussions and it may be conditional, the sources said.

There was no response from Tata Sons to an email seeking confirmation and clarification.

RIISING LOSSES

Media reports have indicated that the losses of the new businesses have widened and been more than expected, raising concerns about the money poured into them.

Tata Trusts, which owns two-thirds stake in Tata Sons, has considerable say in the running of the holding company and Tata Trusts Chairman Noel Tata has been asserting himself more.

In February, at a meeting of the trustees where the re-appointment of Chandra for a third term was supposed to

be approved, the decision was deferred as Noel Tata brought up the question of the loss-making entities, allocation of resources and a clear timeline for their revival.

Along with Noel Tata, some other board members also expressed reservations about the extension to his tenure and Chandra, as he told the media after the meeting, recommended that the decision be deferred, “because of request from some directors”.

Noel Tata also sought an assurance from Chandra that Tata Sons will remain unlisted, and sources said that such a firm undertaking may be difficult to give as it depends on the Reserve Bank of India and how it stands on the issue.

Chandra had assumed charge as Tata Sons Chairman in 2017 for five years, and was reappointed in 2022 for another five years, with the current term ending in February 2027. A further extension was expected to signal continuity in policies and stability.

Pilot duty hour norms eased for long-haul flights

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

The aviation regulator has temporarily relaxed pilot flight duty time limitations (FDTL) for long-haul flights in response to ongoing global aviation disruptions.

The Directorate-General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) extended the FDTL for long-haul operations to accommodate longer flying routes caused by airspace restrictions over the Gulf region.

FDTL are regulatory norms that govern how long pilots and crew can be on duty, including total flight time and mandatory rest periods, in order to manage fatigue and ensure safety.

Under the temporary dispensation, flight time has been extended by 1 hour and 30 minutes to 11-and-a-half hours, while the flight duty period has been increased by

TEMPORARY DISPENSATION

- Flight time has been extended by 1 hour and 30 minutes to 11-and-a-half hours
- The flight duty period has been increased by 1 hour and 45 minutes for select operations
- The relaxation provides flexibility in crew deployment



1 hour and 45 minutes for select operations.

Besides, the relaxation provides flexibility to crew deployment, including permitting some long-haul flights to operate with two pilots and easing roster constraints.

LONG-HAUL OPS

The move has been applied to Air India's long-haul operations and has a broader impact across Indian carriers

operating international routes. “It will be revisited — we still have some time and, of course, it's an evolving situation,” said Asangba Chuba Ao, Joint Secretary (Aviation), Ministry of Civil Aviation.

“As the situation evolves and as we take into consideration what happens in the coming days, this dispensation will be relooked at and, if required, we will take the necessary call at that point of

time. It's till the end of April as of now.”

Per industry insiders, the West Asia crisis has forced airlines to take longer routes over the Red Sea and Egypt to reach destinations in Europe and North America.

These detours have resulted in higher fuel burn and longer flight durations, significantly increasing operating costs.

FINANCIAL STRAIN

Earlier, India-based carriers had warned of potential flight cuts, fleet groundings and job losses, citing mounting financial strain driven by high aviation turbine fuel prices, a weak rupee and high airport charges.

Before the disruptions, Indian airlines operated 300-350 daily flights to the Gulf region. This number has now dropped to approximately 90, with cancellations driven by the prevailing situation.

India's first commercial fast breeder reactor goes critical after 15-year delay

M Ramesh
Chennai

India's first commercial fast breeder reactor, the 500 MW prototype fast breeder reactor (PFBR), has just gone “critical” — meaning a sustained chain reaction has begun inside the reactor, a step before it starts generating electricity.

When the construction of the PFBR began in October 2004 at Kalpakkam near Chennai, it was expected to be commissioned in 2011, at a cost of ₹3,482 crore; after several missed target dates, it went critical on Monday, with an expenditure of ₹8,181 crore.

TECHNICAL CHALLENGES

Speaking with *businessline*, Anil Kakodkar, former Chairman of the Atomic Energy Commission, pointed out that the PFBR is “a very hard



Prime Minister Narendra Modi witnessing initiation of core loading of India's indigenous prototype fast breeder reactor at Kalpakkam in Tamil Nadu in March 2024 **PTI**

technology”. Being the first-of-its-kind in India, it poses several technical challenges, he said. For example, it is a sodium-cooled reactor; handling molten sodium, which reacts violently with water or air, is a big challenge. Also, the sodium needs to be kept pure, which is another challenge. Then there are materials and metallurgical issues, requiring, for example, a special, bespoke type of stainless steel.

Asked if India could not

have learnt from Russia — the only country which has an operational fast breeder reactor — Kakodkar said that it was one thing to learn the theory, but “just as you learn to do, here you have to do to learn”.

It typically takes 12-18 months for a nuclear plant to start supplying electricity to the grid from the date of attaining criticality. BHAVINI, the government company set up to build and run fast breeder reactors in India, has

plans for two more at Kalpakkam, and four later at another site.

USING THORIUM

Breeder reactors are so called because they produce more fuel — Plutonium-239 — than they consume. The fuel for a breeder reactor is a mixture of Plutonium-239 and Uranium-238 — the latter turns into the former inside the reactor. If blanketed by thorium, the reactor can also convert thorium into another nuclear fuel Uranium-233.

Fast breeder reactors are important for India because they pave the way for the country to get to use thorium to generate energy. India has the largest reserves of thorium in the world, estimated at 1 million tonnes.

Getting to thorium use can give India long-term energy security.

Also read **p3**

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QUICKLY.

Ultraviolette, Elektrorider expand in Europe markets



Bengaluru: Premium electric motorcycle manufacturer Ultraviolette has partnered with Elektrorider, marking its entry to Hungary, Croatia, Slovakia, Romania, Slovenia and the Czech Republic. With Elektrorider serving as official distributor across these territories, Ultraviolette now has a presence in 19 European countries. Ultraviolette will introduce its performance electric motorcycles in these markets, beginning with F77 Mach 2 and F77 SuperStreet. Building on Elektrorider's established retail presence, Ultraviolette is well-positioned for a successful entry and sustained growth. **OUR BUREAU**

Macquarie sells Safeway Concessions stake to Vinci Highways for ₹15,000 cr

ROAD MAP. The portfolio includes nine toll road assets across Andhra Pradesh and Gujarat

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Macquarie Asset Management has announced the sale of its interest in Safeway Concessions to Vinci Highways, a subsidiary of Vinci, at an implied enterprise value of about ₹15,000 crore (around \$1.7 billion). The Macquarie Asia Infrastructure Fund 2 includes nine toll highway concessions in Andhra Pradesh and Gujarat. It covers nearly 700 km of highway sections linking important industrial, agricultural and logistical areas. In Andhra Pradesh, it is located on the NH-16 corridor, part of the 'Golden Quadrilateral' linking Kolk-

ata to Chennai, while in Gujarat, it serves most industrialised regions. The completion of the deal is subject to customary closing conditions, including approvals from the relevant regulatory authorities. Financial close is expected by the end of 2026. **SAFEWAY'S GROWTH** Safeway was established under the National Highways Authority of India's toll-operate-transfer (TOT) model in 2018. Since acquiring Safeway in 2018, MAM has established local operations and expanded into three offices, building a strong management team and implementing global standards across safety, governance and risk

VERENA LIM
Asia CEO, Macquarie Group

management. Under MAM's ownership, the platform also implemented sustainability plans in 2023, installed LED street lighting, added electric vehicles and procured truck-mounted attenuators to enhance worker protection in active work zones. The scale and quality of



the highway portfolio present a rare opportunity in a fast-growing market and support Vinci Highways' long-term mobility infrastructure strategy, reflecting its first entry into India's roads sector. Verena Lim, Co-Head of Asia-Pacific Macquarie Asset

Management Infrastructure and Asia CEO for Macquarie Group, said India had the world's second-largest road network, with a rapidly growing middle class, driving higher demand for road usage. **STRATEGIC INVESTORS** "The deal reinforces the long-term viability of the TOT privatisation model while attracting international strategic investors such as Vinci," she added. "It is one of the largest pioneer foreign investors in India's infrastructure sector; we continue to see compelling long-term opportunities across the market from transport to digital and energy infrastructure," she noted.

Adrenalin eSystems eyes revenue boost with labour codes compliance product

Sindhu Hariharan
Chennai

Human capital management (HCM) and payroll solutions provider Adrenalin eSystems has doubled its revenue in the last three years on geographic expansion across international markets, growing product depth and an increasing share of large enterprises among clientele. An associate company of the publicly-listed Intellect Design Arena, it now estimates a further revenue boost from a new platform that helps enterprises comply with the new labour codes.

The company is launching WageSync, a managed services platform offering that helps CHROs and CFOs to work together and design employee pay structure in compliance with the new labour codes, and simulate and understand its impact across every employee. As organisations scramble to comply with the new labour codes effective April 1, most HR and finance teams are relying on spreadsheets and manual processes to estimate business impact.

Adrenalin hopes to address this gap through WageSync, Srinivasa Bharathy, its Managing Director and CEO, told *businessline*. "A few existing customers of Adrenalin are already trying out the product; we expect additional annual revenue of at least ₹20 crore from the product as a separate revenue stream," he added.

The MD and CEO expects this to go beyond one-time use. Depending on organisation size, companies may undertake this as a regular exercise to assess compliance. "It would take the next 3 to 6 months [for organisations to comply with the labour codes] given the practical considerations," he



Srinivasa Bharathy, MD and CEO, Adrenalin eSystems

anticipated. At least 70-75 per cent of organisations would want to finish it this quarter, he said.

A PIONEER Founded in 2002, Adrenalin is a pioneer in HR tech and has evolved through several product iterations. From its early focus on payroll and administrative automation, Adrenalin is now a full-suite, AI-native, cloud-based HR platform spanning the "candidate-to-alumni" journey.

The company has invested about ₹30-40 crore in the last 3-4 years to up its AI game, building an AI layer on top of Intellect's native, enterprise-grade AI platform Purple Fabric. These include conversational agents for user interaction and autonomous agents that handle backend processes. It has also partnered with Intellect to launch a separate product HR TeamSpace, a secure, collaborative AI environment for HR teams.

Sixty per cent of the business comes from India and 40 per cent from overseas, including West Asia, Africa, and Southeast Asia. Given the war in West Asia, Bharathy said decision-making from new prospects had been slightly slower but they had not seen any major loss of momentum.

Board to firm up transition plan as Air India CEO Wilson resigns

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

Veteran aviation executive Campbell Wilson resigned as Chief Executive Officer and Managing Director of Air India, the airline said on Tuesday.

It stated that Wilson will continue in his current role until a successor is appointed and assumes charge. The move formalises a leadership transition that has been under discussion since 2024.

Air India Chairman N Chandrasekaran said, "On behalf of the board, I wish to record my deep appreciation for Campbell's leadership and contribution over the past four years. In addition to the progress mentioned, it is also worth acknowledging the numerous external chal-

lenges navigated by the Air India team, including prolonged post-Covid supply chain constraints that have impacted delivery of new aircraft and retrofit programmes as well as major geopolitical and other headwinds. Campbell and his team have demonstrated tenacity and resolve and have aligned an organisation drawn from many backgrounds behind the shared goal of building the new Air India that is now emerging."

Meantime, the Air India board constituted a committee that will find a successor in the coming months.

As per Air India, Wilson conveyed his intention to step down to Tata Sons Chairman Chandrasekaran in 2024 and has since been working towards organisational stability and leader-

ship-readiness. Sources indicated to *businessline* that the decision was communicated to the board last week (March 30), with a formal transition roadmap expected to be taken up at a board meeting scheduled for early May.

CHALLENGING YEAR

The development comes after a challenging year (2025). A combination of airspace closures across Pakistan, Iran and Iraq, geopolitical tensions affecting travel demand, and the AI171 incident resulted in operational disruptions. Financially, the airline is estimated to be facing losses in the range of ₹8,000-10,000 crore for FY26.

According to sources, the situation even prompted the board to review its profitability



Campbell Wilson was appointed CEO & MD of Air India in 2022, after Tata Group reacquired the airline

ty strategy, with the possibility of moving away from the earlier "Road to Profitability" framework.

Meanwhile, in an internal communication to employees, Wilson outlined the progress made since the airline's privatisation. He cited the merger of four airlines, mod-

ernisation of systems and processes, fleet expansion, and investments in training and maintenance infrastructure as key milestones.

Besides, he added that the airline had inducted over 100 aircraft, initiated infrastructure projects, including a large training academy, and enhanced service and operational standards.

FLEET EXPANSION

Referring to the upcoming phase of fleet expansion, he said the timing was appropriate to transition leadership ahead of bulk aircraft deliveries expected from 2027.

Further, he acknowledged operational challenges, including supply chain constraints, aircraft delivery delays, geopolitical developments and airspace restrictions. Wilson noted the role

of employees in managing these disruptions.

Earlier this year, he spoke to *businessline* about the progress made under the Vihaan.AI programme, and Air India's multi-year turnaround plan "that was largely on track". A majority of the 22 identified lines of improvement are expected to be completed within the originally envisaged FY27-28 timeline. His successor will face a tough operating environment, with jet fuel prices likely to remain at elevated levels and the restoration of the international network contingent on an early resolution of the Gulf crisis.

Wilson was appointed Chief Executive Officer and Managing Director of Air India in 2022, shortly after the Tata Group reacquired the airline from the government.

QCIL inks deals with Ampin Energy, Radiance Renewables for sustainable energy transition

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Quality Care India Ltd has formalised agreements with Ampin Energy and Radiance Renewables under its group captive solar initiative to procure renewable solar power for five facilities in Odisha, Chhattisgarh and Maharashtra. This marks its first phase of transitioning towards sustainable energy, the hospitals company added.

Quality Care India Ltd (QCIL) plans to transition 19 hospitals under Care Hospitals and Kims Health to renewable energy in a phased manner, with phase-I covering Odisha, Chhattisgarh and Maharashtra, followed by Andhra Pradesh and Tamil Nadu in phase-II, Kerala in phase-III, and Madhya Pradesh and Telangana in phase-IV. The initiative is to

ensure operational continuity while scaling renewable adoption across high-dependency healthcare assets, it added.

"Hospitals operate in a continuous, high-dependency environment where energy reliability is critical to patient care. The shift towards renewable energy is both a strategic and operational priority, supporting cost optimisation, energy security and environmental responsibility. With energy costs forming a significant share of hospital operating expenses, the transition is increasingly emerging as a strategic lever across the healthcare sector," a statement from the company said.

QCIL targets a total renewable capacity of approximately 30 MW across its network, with Phase I accounting for around 6 MWp, the note added.

Over the long term, the



group aims to meet nearly 80 per cent of its total energy consumption through renewables, supported by a hybrid model combining solar with wind and battery energy storage systems (BESS), it added.

Furthermore, it said the transition was expected to reduce its annual electricity costs by 20 per cent, along with improved cost visibility and insulation from tariff volatility, critical for maintaining cost stability in en-

ergy-intensive healthcare operations. From an environmental perspective, Phase I is expected to reduce carbon emissions by approximately 8,000 tonnes annually, with the full rollout projected to offset nearly 40,000 tonnes per year across all facilities, QCIL noted.

GROUP CAPTIVE MODEL

"The projects are being implemented under the group captive model, combining long-term renewable power procurement with equity participation," the company said. "This structure enables QCIL to secure reliable, cost-effective clean energy while ensuring regulatory alignment and long-term supply stability," it added.

Ampin Energy will service QCIL's facilities in Odisha and Chhattisgarh, while Radiance Renewables will execute the Maharashtra projects.

Minor Hotels hits sweet spot in India; to scale up to 50 properties in a decade

Aneesh Phadnis
Mumbai

Minor Hotels has hit the sweet spot in India and will scale up its presence to 50 properties in the next 10 years, Founder-Chairman William E Heinecke said on Tuesday. Minor Hotels is headquartered in Thailand and has 640 plus properties in over 60 countries under 12 different brands.

In India, the group runs a luxury hotel under its famed Anantara brand in Jaipur and has signed up for two more hotels under the same brand in Kolkata and Coorg.

"India is on its way to becoming the third largest economy in the world. There is tremendous amount of growth taking place in India. Domestic travel is growing. There is a lot of awareness about our brands: the

There is a lot of awareness about our brands, the Anantara, Avani or even NH Hotels **WILLIAM E HEINECKE** Founder-Chairman, Minor Hotels



Anantara, Avani or even NH Hotels. Demand is much greater than what it was five years ago. I think we have hit the sweet spot," Heinecke told *businessline* ahead of Hotel Investment Conference South Asia in Mumbai.

INDIA COMPLEXITIES

Heinecke, a Thai citizen of US origin, has been in the hospitality business for over 25 years. Alongside, he has interests in business aviation

and quick service restaurant chains. The group, however, has been slow to enter India.

Asked about that, Heinecke said the chain was focused on expanding in other countries initially. Complexities of doing business in India was an issue. "It is critical to have good partners. It has helped us in the Middle East and other markets where we have established partners. Hence, we are here to meet existing and potential part-

ners." He said India, China and Indonesia are big focus markets for Minor Hotels.

Heinecke is also planning to scale up Thai restaurant brand Sanook Kitchen in India. Currently, it has three outlets and the company is looking for more franchisees. The ongoing conflict in West Asia has disrupted travel plans, made airfares costlier and caused shortage of gas and fertilizer. Minor Hotels too is facing an impact, especially in West Asia and the Maldives.

Heinecke, however, believes that recovery in the tourism sector will be quick on cessation of the conflict. "Through all the crises, whether tsunami or the Covid-19 pandemic, what has surprised everyone is how quickly the tourism industry recovers. I would expect it to be no different this time," he said.

'Rising costs, delayed summer pose challenges for AC industry'

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

Rising raw material costs due to the West Asia conflict alongside unseasonal rains could make it a "tough summer" for residential air-conditioners' industry, Blue Star MD B Thiagarajan said. However, he added while summer in some parts got delayed, double-digit growth is anti-



cipated. "The good news is summer has set in in the southern States and even in Maharashtra and Gujarat. But in some other parts there is inclement weather and summer is perhaps delayed. Still, the projections suggest above-normal temperatures at quite a few locations."

"Unfortunately, we got other headwinds. There is a price increase due to higher

input costs. And there is the burden of war... It is going to be a tough summer," he added.

1.75 LAKH UNITS

Thiagarajan expects double-digit revenue growth of 20 per cent over last year. "Our plan is to sell 1.75 lakh units of ACs," he added. The company, which took a price hike of 8 per cent earlier this year due to revised energy efficiency ratings, is expected to initiate a fresh round of hikes of 5 per cent this month due to high raw material costs and rupee depreciation as demand picks up. On Tuesday, it launched a portfolio of 125 models of room ACs, including a flagship premium range, complying with the new Bureau of Energy Efficiency (BEE) standards.

Dunkin' exit puts India's QSR middle ground on notice

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

In the corporate corridors of Noida and Mumbai's BKC, a quiet rationalisation is underway. Within 48 hours, Jubilant FoodWorks Ltd (JFL) took two decisive calls: It exited Dunkin' and renewed Domino's franchise for 15 years signalling a structural shift in India's quick-service restaurant (QSR) market.

The numbers made the Dunkin' decision inevitable. The brand contributed just 0.61 per cent to JFL's FY25 revenue while posting a loss of ₹19.1 crore. JFL has now opted for an "orderly and phased" exit ahead of the franchise expiry in December 2026.

"In the QSR theatre, the middle ground has become a graveyard," said Harish Bijoor, marketing and brand



PRICING DILEMMA. Across the QSR landscape, operators are moving away from growth-at-any-cost to what industry executives describe as 'profitable density'

strategy expert and Founder, Harish Bijoor Consults.

"You are either a habit priced for the common pocket or an experience priced for the elite. Dunkin' fell into the crack in between, too expensive to be a daily ritual, yet too functional to be a premium aspiration," he added. Experts say

at roughly ₹300 for a coffee-and-doughnut pairing, the brand offered limited satiety.

"In a high-inflation environment, Indian consumers treat doughnuts as a discretionary add-on, not a replacement meal. Dunkin' now joins Wendy's and Burger King in a growing list of global brands forced to recal-

ibrate in India," said an analyst at a brokerage firm.

CLOUD-FIRST

Wendy's India has adopted a cloud-first model, scaling to over 175 touchpoints, with nearly 90 per cent operating as delivery-only kitchens. Café Coffee Day has shrunk from over 1,700 cafés to around 450-470 outlets, pivoting towards vending machines and packaged coffee. Operators are moving away from growth-at-any-cost to what industry executives describe as "profitable density". The pressure is visible at the premium end as well. Pret A Manger of Reliance Retail entered with ₹450-500 sandwiches but has since introduced a ₹149-249 range, along with a locally rooted 'Bombay Toastie' at ₹295. "While you can import a Wall Street aesthetic, you will still see the British

butler whip up a Bombay toastie out of respect for the Mumbai wallet," Bijoor said. "Premiumness is a hook, but affordability is the reel."

Jubilant's playbook reflects the shift. While exiting Dunkin', it is scaling another QSR brand, Popeyes, and doubling down on Domino's. With over 2,100 stores built around the ₹99-₹199 band, Jubilant effectively dominates the highest-velocity segment in Indian QSR. In comparison, McDonald's anchors demand with its ₹99 McAlloo Tikki, while KFC and Burger King have moved to similar entry points.

"As Pret A Manger, Tim Hortons and Guzman y Gomez scale up in FY27, the market is sending a clear signal: this is not a ₹500-sandwich economy. It is a ₹199 habit market, miss that, and scale will remain elusive," Bijoor added.

QUICKLY.

India, New Zealand may sign FTA on April 24

New Delhi: India and New Zealand are expected to sign a free trade agreement (FTA) on April 24 here, which will provide tariff-free access to domestic exporters for their goods in the island nation's market, and will bring in \$20 billion of investment over the next 15 years, an official said. The two countries on December 22 last year announced the conclusion of negotiations for the trade deal which aims at doubling bilateral trade to \$5 billion in the next five years. **PII**

TAFE opens JFarm in Rajasthan

Chennai: Tractors and Farm Equipment (TAFE) inaugurated its adaptive research centre, TAFE JFarm Rajasthan, at Bhawani Mandi. "This facility aims to empower farmers with practical insights and real-time demonstrations, helping them improve productivity and efficiency," a company statement said. The centre will showcase the latest advancements in agronomy. **OUR BUREAU**

How fast breeder reactors can ensure India is completely energy-secure

M Ramesh
Chennai

Other than coal, which emits copious quantities of the dreaded carbon dioxide, the biggest energy source with India is thorium. India has about a million tonnes of it, the most in the world.

Thorium is a potential nuclear fuel, but it must first be converted into uranium-233, whose atomic nuclei can be split, to produce energy.

Fast breeder reactors, sometimes called fast neutron reactors, convert thorium into U-233 very efficiently — because they are filled with buzzing neutrons that bombard thorium and make it U-233.

That is the importance of the 500-MW Prototype Fast Breeder Reactor (PFBR), which went critical on Monday. In nuclear-speak, going critical means that a sustained chain reaction has started inside the reactor core, producing heat.

With the learnings from the PFBR, India plans to build two more fast breeder reactors at the Kalpakkam nuclear energy complex near Chennai, and four more elsewhere, perhaps even more later.

While these could take a couple of decades, they can provide India long-term energy security, lasting several centuries.

First, it must be understood that the fuel for a breeder reactor is Plutonium-239 (Pu-239),

For the war-hit sectors, Centre plans ₹2.5 lakh crore credit guarantee scheme

LIQUIDITY SUPPORT. It is likely to provide a 90 per cent credit guarantee for loans, would be valid for four years

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

The Union Cabinet is expected to soon take a call on the credit guarantee scheme to support various sectors affected by the West Asia war.

The scheme, a version of the Emergency Credit Line Guarantee Scheme (ECLGS), is expected to cover loans worth ₹2.5 lakh crore and would be valid for four years, a senior government official told here. Further, it is likely to provide a 90 per cent credit guarantee for loans from the National Credit Guarantee Trustee Company. The fund will cover the loss in the event of the borrower's default.

"Effort is to extend support across sectors, including aviation, MSMEs and even other businesses that are currently facing liquidity pressures," the official said, specifically highlighting the aviation sector, which is facing disruptions in routes,



PANDEMIC AID. The ECLGS was launched in May 2020 as a special initiative to provide liquidity support to businesses impacted by the Covid-19 pandemic lockdown

costs and operations. He also highlighted the success of the ECLGS.

ECLGS SCALE-UP

"It has been effective in supporting businesses during stress periods, but the current situation requires a significant scale-up. We are looking at enhancing both the scope and the overall limit of the scheme so that a larger set of sectors and enterprises can access guaranteed credit more easily," he said. ECLGS was launched in

May 2020 as a special initiative to provide liquidity support to businesses adversely impacted by the Covid lockdown.

The scheme covered all loans sanctioned under 'Guaranteed Emergency Credit Line' up to March 31, 2023, or until guarantees for an amount of ₹5 lakh crore are issued, whichever is earlier. Borrowers did not need to provide any additional security or collateral to avail of these loans. Interest rates were capped at

9.25 per cent for banks and 14 per cent for NBFCs. Also, the scheme offered a one-year moratorium on principal repayment, though interest was payable during this period.

It provided 100 per cent guarantee coverage to banks and NBFCs on credit extended to business enterprises/MSMEs, based on their loan outstanding as on February 29, 2020, to meet their additional term loan/additional working capital requirements.

Initially, it was mainly for MSMEs, but later it was expanded to include borrowers from 26 stressed sectors identified by the Kamath Committee, as well as the healthcare and hospitality sectors.

LIQUIDITY SUPPORT

Out of the liquidity support of ₹3.68 lakh crore to 1.19 crore businesses, the share of MSMEs was 95 per cent in terms of the number of guaranties and about 65 per cent

in terms of the amount of guarantees issued. In terms of the number of borrowers supported, 88 per cent are micro borrowers, 78 per cent are MUDRA borrowers and 68 per cent are women borrowers.

According to officials, out of the total liquidity support, NPAs reported are around ₹22,000 crore, or 6 per cent, on loans guaranteed. The scheme was mentioned in the World Bank's World Development Report 2022.

ECONOMIC RECOVERY

It was said that the true cost of these guarantees to the government will only become clear in the long term. Although India's economic recovery from the first waves of the pandemic has been remarkably robust, and the immediate fiscal impact of credit guarantee schemes is low, credit guarantees always carry the risk of becoming a liability for the government if an economic downturn causes loan defaults to rise.

Centre adds 2 conditions for States to access tied funds under SASCI

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

The Centre has added two new conditions for States to access tied funds under the Special Assistance to States for Capital Investment (SASCI) scheme: implementing "Right of Way" (RoW) rules for the telecom sector and linking Farmer IDs on AgriStack with fertilizer usage. Meanwhile, existing reforms related to the mining and road sectors will continue. The Budget for FY27 allocated ₹2 lakh crore to the scheme.

According to a senior government official, the Finance Ministry has notified States that ₹1.75 lakh crore is currently available, with ₹25,000 crore held as a buffer. Of the available funds, ₹1.05 lakh crore is "tied" to the completion of specific reforms, while ₹70,000 crore remains "untied" for general capital expenditure.

Regarding the RoW reform, the official noted: "While Right of Way rules already exist, States must now notify and implement them to ensure their agencies comply." The RoW framework provides a standardised mechanism to expedite approvals and facilitate the deployment of telecom infrastructure while protecting public assets.

The rules balance the need for infrastructure development with public interest, ensuring safety and fairness. Expenditure Secretary Vumlungmang Vualnam previously told *businessline*:

"Standardising and streamlining these rules through SASCI will ensure the smooth, nationwide expansion of India's telecom network."

The second new reform involves linking Farmer IDs on AgriStack with fertilizer usage to improve farmer databases and support systems.

DATA MAINTENANCE

The goal is to strengthen data maintenance, ensuring that support systems, such as fertilizer subsidies, are more targeted and effective. AgriStack is a federated Digital Public Infrastructure where data ownership rests with the States. It includes three key registries maintained by State governments or Union Territories: geo-referenced village maps, crop sown registry and the farmers registry. Using this platform will help eliminate duplicate beneficiaries and enhance subsidy monitoring.

Govt doubles 5-kg LPG cylinder supply for migrant labourers

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

The Ministry of Petroleum & Natural Gas has doubled the daily supply of 5-kg free trade LPG (FTL) cylinders to States for supply to migrant labourers. The order, released on Monday by the Ministry, will not only help increase the supply of the critical cooking fuel to labourers, but also help raise daily sales to more than one lakh units.

"It is conveyed that the daily quantity of 5-kg FTL cylinder in each State, available for disbursal to migrant labourers, is being doubled based on average daily supply to migrant labourers during March 2-3, 2026, beyond limit of 20 per cent mentioned in Para 2(a) of letter of March 21. These 5-kg FTL cylinders will be at disposal of State governments/its Food/Civil Supplies Department for supplying only to migrant labourers in their State with the assistance of OMCs," the order said.

On March 21, the Centre allowed additional allocation of 20 per cent commercial LPG to States on "priority basis" for 5-kg FTL cylinders for migrant labourers as well as sectors such as restaurants, dhabas, hotels, industrial canteens, food processing/dairy, subsidised canteens/outlets run by State or local bodies for food, community kitchens.

In the last 25 days, around 79,909 tonnes of commercial LPG have been sold, which is equivalent to more than 42 lakh 19-kg cylinders. Since March 23, roughly 6.6 lakh 5-kg FTL cylinders have been sold across States.

HIGHER ALLOCATION

Higher allocation helped boost the supply of the critical cooking resource for migrant labourers. For instance, around 37,000 5-kg FTL cylinders were sold on March 25, rising to more than 90,000 on April 4.

Officials said that even as the LPG supply situation is "concerning," given that the conflict in West Asia is far from over and the Strait of Hormuz (SoH) remains closed, the Centre has assured complete supply to households, hospitals, educational institutions and migrant workers.

On April 2, the States, in a meeting with Oil Secretary Neeraj Mittal, clarified that there is no disruption in LPG supply affecting migrants and that supplies remain stable.

Mittal suggested that States focus on distribution in consultation with the PSU oil marketing companies (OMCs).

PSU OMCs are also organising awareness campaigns for migrant workers. For instance, they have so far organised around 550 such camps in around 25 States and Union Territories.



NUCLEAR POWER. The prototype fast breeder reactor of 500 MW at Kalpakkam

which is not available in nature, but gets produced in conventional uranium-based nuclear reactors. Natural uranium comes in two varieties.

U-238, which is 99.3 per cent of natural uranium, is useless mud; the other variety, U-235, is the hero of nuclear energy.

By increasing the concentration of U-235 (called "enrichment"), typically, to about 3-4 per cent, and by bombarding it with neutrons, heat energy is produced, which is converted into electrical energy. During this process, some of the U-238 gets converted into another man-made material called Pu-239.

If you take a mixture of Pu-239 and U-238 and put it into a fast breeder reactor, even the U-238 gets converted into more Pu-239. This way, the reactor produces more Pu-239 than it consumes — hence it is called 'breeder'.

Now, a fast breeder reactor can do three things together. One, generate electricity; two, convert U-238 into Pu-239; and three, if blanketed by thorium, convert thorium into U-233. There is a trade-off between producing Pu-239 and U-233 — if you ask the reactor to produce U-233 too, it will produce less of Pu-239.

Experts such as Anil Kakodkar, India's pre-eminent nuclear scientist and former Chairman of the Atomic Energy Commission, advocate prioritising production of Pu-239 over U-233, so as to build enough stocks of Pu-239.

Once you have enough Pu-239, you can use it in reactors to generate electricity and cook U-233.

NUCLEAR PROGRAMME

Thus, you have a sequential three-stage nuclear programme, as envisaged by Homi Bhabha, the father of India's nuclear energy — us-

ing uranium in the first stage, plutonium in the second and thorium in the third, which can last centuries.

PFBR attaining criticality is a significant milestone in India stepping into the second stage. The third stage — the thorium cycle — is still decades away, but when India gets into it, it would be completely energy-secure.

OTHER WAYS

There are other ways of converting thorium into U-233. Fast breeder reactors do it most efficiently, but you can still put a 'thorium blanket' around a conventional thermal reactor. India is a leader in 'pressurised heavy water reactor' (PHWR) technology, operating about 20 of them. Ten more PHWRs, of 700 MW each, are under construction. It is technically possible to use these reactors to convert thorium into U-233.

Then there is another route, called 'accelerator driven subcritical system', or ADSS, under development for over 25 years. The ADSS is a machine that can generate neutrons that can be used to bombard thorium and make U-233.

Thus, there are at least three ways of making the nuclear fuel U-233 from thorium—in fast breeder reactors (the most efficient way), conventional reactors and ADSS.

Experts are of the view that India must pursue all three ways to quickly start tapping into its abundant thorium reserves.

Misri to review 'full spectrum' of ties with top US officials in Washington

Amiti Sen
New Delhi



Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri

significance as the Office of the US Trade Representative recently initiated two sweeping Section 301 investigations, both of which prominently feature India on their target lists. The first, launched on March 11, probes structural excess manufacturing capacity across 16 economies, alleging that State-backed overproduction in sectors such as solar, steel and textiles is distorting global markets. The second, initiated on March 12, examines 60 major trading partners, including India, over their alleged failure to effectively

Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri will be on a three-day visit to Washington this week to engage senior US officials on trade, defence and global developments amid ongoing trade investigations, fluid tariffs and a volatile security situation in West Asia. Misri's visit, on April 8-10, will provide an opportunity to review the "full spectrum" of India-US bilateral relations and advance ongoing cooperation across key areas, per a statement issued by the Ministry of External Affairs on Tuesday. "During the visit, the Foreign Secretary will hold discussions with senior officials of the US administration on a wide range of issues, including trade, defence, science and technology, as well as regional and global developments of mutual interest," it said. The visit takes on added

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enforce prohibitions on goods produced with forced labour.

Misri may use the visit to place before US officials India's defence in both cases to stop them from escalating into new tariff regimes.

CRITICAL DEADLINE

With a critical deadline for written comments set for April 15, the Foreign Secretary's discussions are expected to serve as a vital diplomatic channel to address these probes before they potentially escalate into new tariff regimes.

The statement also noted that the discussions would cover regional and global developments of mutual interest, which is expected due to the escalation in the ongoing West Asia crisis.

Misri may also discuss a possible extension of the sanctions waiver for the strategic Chabahar port India is helping develop in Iran. The waiver is currently set to expire on April 26.

GAIL inks long-term charter party agreement for LNG carrier

Our Bureau
New Delhi

State-run GAIL said on Tuesday that it has entered into a long-term charter party agreement with Greek shipping firm Alpha Gas for the LNG carrier *Energy Fidelity*.

The charter party agreement was executed between GAIL and Pantheon Maritime Services, a Singapore based affiliate of Alpha Gas.

The LNG carrier *Energy Fidelity*, with a cargo capacity of 174,000 cubic metres, is equipped with a state-of-the-art two-stroke propulsion system, complemented by advanced air lubrication technology and shaft generators, collectively enhancing fuel efficiency and significantly reducing emissions.

The move is part of India's efforts to establish a liquefied natural gas (LNG) supply chain.

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Notice is hereby given that pursuant to SEBI Circular SEBI/HO/MIRSD/DOS3/CIR/P/2018/139 dated 6th November 2018, a request has been received by the Company from Name(s) of Proposed Transferee(s) **SANDEEP KARWA**, residing at **F-202, BAHAR IN VASANT NAGARI SECTOR 3 CHS LTD, VASANT NAGARI, VASAI EAST, 401208** to transfer the below mentioned securities held in the name(s) of the securityholder(s) as detailed below, to his name. These securities were claimed to have been purchased by him and could not be transferred in his favour.

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Any person who has a claim in respect of the abovementioned securities, should lodge such claim with the Company at its Registered Office within 30 days from this date along with appropriate documentary evidence thereof in support of such claim, else the Company will proceed to transfer the securities in favour of SANDEEP KARWA (Names of the Proposed Transferee), without any further intimation.

For TTK Prestige Limited
Manjula K V
Company Secretary & Compliance Officer

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Company Secretary & Compliance Officer

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Nuclear milestone

Prototype fast breeder reactor, a technological trigger

The 500 MW Prototype Fast Breeder Reactor (PFBR) at the Kalpakkam nuclear energy complex near Chennai has gone critical — meaning, a sustained nuclear chain reaction has begun inside the reactor, a prelude to electricity generation. It is a heartening milestone, even if the PFBR suffered a 15-year delay and cost ₹8,181 crore, against the originally estimated ₹3,492 crore. The time and cost overruns seem unconscionably high, but they deserve condonation because building fast breeder reactors is technically very challenging.



Only Russia operates them commercially; France and Japan abandoned their efforts after finding the technical challenge unnecessary, while the US stepped back largely on economic considerations. China's CFR-600 is in its early stage of operation. Thus, India is on the cusp of becoming only the third country in the world to have a commercial fast breeder reactor. It will be 12-18 months before the PFBR starts supplying electricity to the grid, after tests and turbine synchronisation. It is important for the various arms of the Department of Atomic Energy to ensure that all projects — those under implementation and planned — are fast-tracked. BHAVINI, the government company set up to build and operate breeder reactors, should lose no time in implementing the plan to build two more breeder reactors at the same site, and four more elsewhere.

The PFBR is fuelled by a mixture of oxides of plutonium-239 and uranium-238, both of which come from the conventional pressurized heavy water reactors that India runs. The PFBR is a 'breeder' — it produces more Pu-239 than it consumes, by converting U-238 into more Pu-239. Hopefully, the next two breeder reactors will use metallic fuel — a mixture of pure Pu-239 and U-238 rather than their oxides — to increase the breeding ratio so that more Pu-239 is produced. Metallic fuels are the holy grail of fast breeder reactors; India should make the shift to metallic fuels, however tough, a high priority. Once sufficient inventory of Pu-239 is built, India can move to the thorium cycle.

Fast breeder reactors can also convert thorium — which India has in plenty — into another fissile material, uranium-233. However, producing U-233 from thorium comes at the cost of Pu-239 production. While India should prioritise Pu-239, it should explore other ways of converting thorium into U-233. There are several options. This includes an 'accelerator-driven subcritical system' (ADSS) — a method of irradiating thorium to produce U-233. The ADSS project has been on the anvil at the Bhabha Atomic Research Centre since 2001 and should be fast-tracked. Further, the DAE should take up construction of the 300 MW Advanced Heavy Water Reactor thorium reactor, for which the design is ready. Alongside, the government should address the delays that continue to dog several other projects under the Department of Atomic Energy — such as the ₹9,859-crore fast reactor fuel cycle facility.

POCKET RAVIKANTH



PRITAM BANERJEE

MC14 was framed as the "reform" ministerial, but the core debate was whose interests those reforms would serve. At its heart, this debate reflects global economic competition, primarily the struggle between Western powers and a rising China.

Western proposals for WTO reform advocated for the selective denial of Most Favoured Nation (MFN) status and a shift away from consensus-based decision-making. From a developing country point of view, these structural anchors are vital. MFN prevents discrimination against less powerful nations, while consensus stops dominant powers from steamrolling the minority. Abandoning them risks regressing the global trading system into a power-based hierarchy.

Additionally, the US proposal sought to deny Special and Differential Treatment to large developing nations like India. By stripping away these flexibilities, the industrialized West was effectively pre-empting the industrial policies that developing countries need to grow, seeking to deny the policy advantages the industrialized West itself enjoyed for decades during their growth phase. While China is the overt target, the deeper goal is longer-term gatekeeping, thereby ensuring no other nation can replicate China's rise or challenge Western dominance.

Ironically, China may welcome this transition. In a power-driven system stripped of rules-based safeguards, China is uniquely positioned to weaponise its supply chains and extract concessions, replacing a multilateral order with one dictated by raw economic leverage.

INDIA'S PRINCIPLED DEFENCE
The US and EU proposals caused serious concern among developing countries in the run-up to the MC14. As was expected, there was significant pushback against these proposals. India played a key role in ensuring that the WTO reform pathway that emerges out of Yaoundé was open-ended and non-prescriptive, allowing for much greater debate on how WTO must reform itself.

While India was not alone in pushing back against the wider set of issues designed to undermine the level playing field for developing countries, there was one area where it found itself fighting a lone battle: on the issue of incorporation of the plurilateral agreement on investment facilitation for development or IFD.

While some developing countries did



India's strategic defiance at the WTO meet

PLURILATERAL THREAT. India's recognised that the innocuous sounding investment facilitation for development was a threat to consensus-based rule making

highlight the need to ensure that plurilateral agreements did not end up creating a fragmented system of global rules and argued in favour of some guardrails, no one was willing to oppose the incorporation of the plurilateral Investment Facilitation for Development (IFD) agreement into the WTO system.

The proponents of IFD had strategically pushed it forward as an instrument of greater good and of interest to developing countries. Numerous studies and opinion pieces were marshalled to provide 'evidence' that the IFD would lead to significant increases in investment into developing countries. Any opposition to the IFD was therefore be painted as 'anti-development'.

Indian policymakers viewed the IFD through a broader geopolitical lens. While agreeing that plurilaterals can advance niche rulemaking, India recognised they often serve as instruments of power play. By design,

Closed plurilaterals bypass MFN principles and circumvent the consensus-based rulemaking central to the WTO, allowing a subset of members to set global norms without the "grand bargains" required by multilateralism

closed plurilaterals bypass Most Favoured Nation (MFN) principles and circumvent the consensus-based rulemaking central to the WTO, allowing a subset of members to set global norms without the "grand bargains" required by multilateralism.

Initiatives like the Global Forum for Excess Steel Capacity (GFSEC) illustrate the danger. Led by the EU, US, and Japan, GFSEC proposes common tariff and non-tariff measures in the steel sector that can distort trade and inhibit technology transfer to developing nations.

While initiatives like GFSEC exist outside the WTO today, lack of adequate guardrails will allow a multitude of such plurilaterals to become part of WTO discussions. This would paralyse the multilateral system by shifting focus away from genuine developmental interests and allow dominant powers to impose costs on those who resist lopsided norms. The US intent to pursue plurilateral rulemaking whether within or outside the WTO further underlines the systemic challenge confronting the global trading system.

Western powers may use plurilaterals to legitimise their industrial policies under environmental or security guises, while marginalising industrial policy programmes of developing nations. China could similarly exploit this power-oriented system to advance its own norm-setting ambitions.

INDIA'S COURAGE UNDER FIRE
Indian policymakers recognised a "toothless" and innocuous agreement

like the IFD was being used as a strategic precedent to normalise the incorporation of plurilateral agreements into the WTO, precisely because it appears non-threatening and can be presented as a 'global good'.

To prevent this erosion of transparent multilateral rulemaking, India resisted the IFD's adoption at Yaoundé, insisting instead that the integration of such agreements be tied to comprehensive WTO reforms. Central to India's position is the establishment of rigorous guardrails. Such potential guardrails include procedural due diligence to verify that a multilateral consensus is unattainable before authorising plurilateral tracks, alongside a requirement for a representative critical mass of participants from across the WTO's diverse membership.

By standing firm despite tremendous diplomatic pressure and isolation, India shielded the multilateral system from fragmentation and unchecked power plays. This principled stance, while publicly solitary, earned private praise from several delegations who recognised the systemic risks at stake.

By linking the issue of incorporation of plurilateral agreements to procedural reforms ensuring adequate guardrails, India has ensured that future rulemaking remains transparent and inclusive, a position likely to be vindicated as the global trade architecture evolves.

The writer is Head, Centre for WTO Studies, Indian Institute of Foreign Trade (IIFT). Views expressed are personal

Sensex has fallen on account of global forces

The Iran war has hastened the exit of FPIs from Indian markets, amidst a rising dollar, putting huge pressure on the rupee

Govind Bhattacharjee

Ever since the war began, on closing price basis, the Indian market has been among the worst performers in Asia, with the Sensex losing around 10 per cent, compared with 7-9 per cent in Kospi (South Korea), 6-8 per cent in Nikkei 225 (Japan), and 3-5 per cent in Hang Seng (Hong Kong) cushioned by mainland inflows, while only the Shanghai Composite Index showed some resilience, declining only by around 1-2 per cent. The Sensex's fall is not a random correction but a global repricing of risk, driven by non-stop FPI outflows, rising US Bond yields and strengthening of the US Dollar Index (DXY).

The FPIs hold roughly 18-20 per cent of India's free-float market capitalisation which was at around \$800 billion in February 26, and have been net sellers in the stock markets for quite some time now. FPIs have withdrawn about ₹1.5 lakh crore, or around 1.5-2 per cent of their total equity holdings since this war began, and during the 15-day stretch from March 4-19, have withdrawn almost ₹90,000 crore, the largest continuous outflow in two decades, making Nifty shed 10 per cent

of its value. The largest outflows are seen in financials, IT, and large-cap consumption stocks which dominate the Sensex. It also points out an inherent weakness of our financial markets in which the FPI determine the marginal price-setting in equities, while domestic investors only buy the shares that the FPIs are selling, but cannot push the market upwards.

Another determinant of the market behaviour is the yield of 10-Year US Treasury Bonds.

Once it crosses the 4.3-4.8 per cent crucial threshold, it outcompetes the risk-adjusted returns on the emerging market equities. The average expected returns from the stock markets in India range between 10-12 per cent, with risk free returns (bank FDs, yield of government bonds) remaining round 5-6 per cent, giving investors an extra return of 4-7 per cent over risk-free assets.

ATTRACTIVE \$ ASSETS
But once markets start falling and the US treasury yields start rising, this equity risk premium of investors collapses, and investing in risk-free dollar bonds becomes attractive. This reallocation in turn strengthens the DXY, as global capital flows into dollar



RUPEE. Under pressure GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTO

assets, exerting pressure on emerging market currencies. Every percentage rise in DXY is associated with sharp decline of emerging market equities and currencies. Between February 27 and March 23, the Sensex plunged to 72,596, falling by 9 per cent. During the same period, the DXY rose by just over 1 per cent, while the Rupee weakened from 91 to almost 94, nearly 3 per cent.

Sustained capital outflows and a stronger dollar will put further pressure on the rupee, which has since beaten 95 to a dollar. With oil prices spiking above \$115 per barrel due to fears of supply disruptions in the Strait of Hormuz, pressure on the rupee is likely to

intensify further. It is widely believed the Indian stock market is highly overvalued, with Price/Earning (PE) Ratio of over 20, about 40-60 per cent higher than their emerging market peers, and a correction was long-overdue. Besides, the Sensex is heavily skewed towards energy, financials and IT. These three sectors are under immense pressure due to geopolitical reasons, margin pressure due to rising cost of funds and the disruptive impact of AI.

While SIPs provide substantial support, they cannot offset large FPI exits. The exits from Indian stocks find entry into US treasury bonds giving over 4 per cent returns, and US stock markets, with the rest moving towards gold, energy assets, and dollar money markets. Sensex is falling not because the economy is underperforming, but because the global opportunity cost of capital is rising. But the US is also facing rising fiscal deficit and debt ratios, imposing limits on prolonged dollar strength. The Fed may be forced to cut rates. Falling US bond yields will drive capital flows back into emerging markets, weakening the dollar – and strengthening the rupee.

The writer is a former Director General of CAG of India

● **LETTERS TO EDITOR** Send your letters by email to bleditor@thehindu.co.in or by post to 'Letters to the Editor', The Hindu Business Line, Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002.

Freebies' fiscal impact

With reference to the Editorial, 'Freebies unplugged' (April 7); the debate on freebies should move beyond moral arguments and focus on fiscal quality and outcome efficiency. Does the government spending deliver? When a rising share of state budgets is locked into politically driven transfers, it reduces flexibility to respond to shocks and crowds out capex. Every major welfare promise must be accompanied by a medium-term fiscal impact statement. Independent state-level fiscal councils could audit such commitments annually. Welfare schemes should be linked to verifiable outcomes like school

attendance, skill certification, maternal health, or energy efficiency so that public money builds human capital instead of just consumption. Crucially, election-time announcements should be regulated through stricter disclosure norms by the Election Commission, making parties accountable for financing plans.

Amarjeet Kumar
Hazariabagh (Jharkhand)

In defence of freebies

More often than not, freebies are the state's direct interface with its citizens. In an economy where consumption is the engine, transfers in kind: free food, power, transport, spur demand far more effectively

than random tax incentives. Freebies double up as instruments of social stability in a deeply unequal society. A subsidized bus ride or a free rations is a hedge against discontent. They do sharpen accountability, as voters can see, feel, and judge delivery in real time. Long-term gains — nutrition, mobility, and access which often translate into better schooling and productivity. Not every freebie is fiscally reckless. Freebies are imperfect, but pragmatic, nevertheless.

R Narayanan
Navi Mumbai

With reference to 'Freebies unplugged' (April 7), the income

inequalities and the uniform indirect tax structure necessitated States to offer such compassionate to the needy. Of course the list of freebies has enlarged over a period of time and has become a powerful election tool now, un mindful of its ramifications on the economy and the taxpayer. As aptly suggested, instead of extending UCTs, the poll manifestos should aim towards enhanced investments in health, education, nutrition and capex for long-ter benefits. As a deterrent unrealistic promises, the election code can be reformed with provisions to recover part of the additional expenditure on account of freebies involved, from the party funds, salaries and other benefits

payable to the elected representatives.

Sitaram Popuri
Bengaluru

Futile exit polls

This refers to 'No exit polls from 7 a.m. of April 9 till 6.30 p.m. of April 29: EC' (April 7). Well done, EC. This move is a big relief for all as exit polls have become farcical. In fact, such polls have led to needless media hype apart from wastage of time and money. It's a different matter that the Opposition political parties may still see 'Red' over it. But, let us not get carried away by that.

SK Gupta
New Delhi

Packaging woes

Iran war hits packaging, downstream sectors

Nida Rahman
Abhishek Singh
Krishan Sharma

The packaging industry occupies a critical role in the ecosystem of manufacturing. However, it is silently bearing the brunt of global conflicts in the Middle East. From biscuits on supermarket shelves to life-saving pharmaceutical products, corrugated boxes and protective materials form the backbone of modern supply chains.

Corrugated box manufacturing relies heavily on heat. In a typical mid-sized unit in Faridabad (Haryana), corrugation machines require sustained high temperatures to shape and bond paper layers into sturdy packaging material. Many such units depend on Liquefied Petroleum Gas (LPG) cylinders as a primary heat source. However, the production process is such that the heating stage occurs every alternate day.

A manufacturer we interviewed, in Faridabad, supplying to large clients such as Britannia Industries and several pharmaceutical firms, reports consuming 4-5 LPG cylinders daily. This dependence makes production highly sensitive to fluctuations in fuel prices. On the ground, the erratic supply and allocation cuts have created space for price distortions, with businesses reporting inconsistent deliveries and, in some cases, inflated prices as high as 4,000 for one cylinder, charged by intermediaries and distributors. Currently, there is no supply of LPG cylinders to packaging units in Faridabad.

GOING A LAYER DEEP

Beyond corrugated boxes, packaging often incorporates thermocol (expanded polystyrene), widely used for cushioning fragile goods. The raw material for thermocol, polypropylene (PP), is largely imported into India, with a significant share coming from China. Industry inputs suggest that prices have nearly doubled since the escalation of tensions involving Iran, the US and Israel. For Indian manufacturers, this has created a dual cost shock: rising energy expenses and surging input costs.

While India has made strides in domestic manufacturing, segments like petrochemical derivatives still remain exposed to international market volatility.

The effects of rising packaging costs are not confined to



TOUGH TIMES. LPG vital for manufacture of corrugated boxes

manufacturers alone. FMCG (fast-moving consumer goods) companies and pharmaceutical firms are heavily dependent on reliable packaging and face increased procurement costs. For FMCG giants like Britannia Industries, packaging is a significant component of total cost. . Companies are thus confronted with difficult choices: absorb the cost increase, pass it on to consumers, or redesign packaging to economise. In the pharmaceutical sector, the stakes are even higher. Packaging is not merely functional but regulatory, ensuring product safety, stability, and compliance.

India's packaging industry is dominated by small and medium enterprises. These firms often lack the bargaining power and financial resilience of larger corporations. As input costs rise, SMEs face a "cost-price squeeze" where production becomes more expensive, but competitive pressures prevent them from raising prices proportionately. The result is a gradual erosion of margins, delayed investments in technology, and in some cases, reduced operational capacity.

Yet, within this disruption lies an unexpected opportunity. Faced with rising LPG costs, some manufacturers are beginning to explore alternative energy solutions, notably solar power. One such unit estimates that installing a basic solar setup would require an investment of approximately ₹30,000-40,000. While modest, this upfront cost represents a strategic shift in how energy is sourced and consumed. The transition is not without challenges. Corrugation processes require consistent and high heat, which solar panels alone may not reliably provide without storage or hybrid solutions. However, even partial substitution, such as using solar energy for auxiliary operations or pre-heating can significantly reduce LPG dependence over time.

Nida and Abhishek are with IILM, New Delhi; Krishan is with Bennett University, Greater Noida

China's perennial industrial policy

TESTING TIMES. China's 15th Five-Year Plan reveals ambition of a different scale. Whether this is achievable hinges on execution



ADITYA SINHA

In the second book of Kautilya's *Arthashastra* (a text that predates Adam Smith by roughly two millennia) there is a chapter devoted to the Superintendent of Metals. Kautilya argued that the state should not merely regulate mining. It should own the smelting works, control quality of output, fix the wages of artisans, and determine which products could flow through private trade and which must pass through royal workshops. The idea that a government could rationally direct an industrial economy is, in that sense, rather old.

China's 15th Five-Year Plan is a restatement of that old idea. The plan covers 2026 to 2030. GDP is to grow within a "reasonable range," calibrated annually, more honest than a fixed target. R&D expenditure is to grow at over 7 per cent per annum in real terms, pushing China towards the 3 per cent of GDP threshold that separates innovation-led economies from catch-up ones (the 14th Plan period recorded 2.8 per cent). High-value invention patents per ten thousand people are to rise from 16 to over 22. The share of core digital economy industries in GDP is to climb from 10.5 per cent to 12.5 per cent, implying roughly 2.5 trillion yuan of additional value-added. The plan carefully distinguishes binding

indicators from expectational ones.

The industrial architecture has three tiers. Traditional sectors (steel, petrochemicals, shipbuilding) are to be upgraded through digital and green technologies, with the "orderly withdrawal of outdated and inefficient production capacity." Strategic emerging industries, covering next-generation information technology, intelligent connected vehicles, robotics, biomedicine, and aerospace, are to be scaled. Future industries (quantum technology, bio-manufacturing, hydrogen energy, nuclear fusion, brain-computer interfaces) are to be seeded, with the plan candidly admitting uncertainty: "exploring diverse technological routes" and building "mechanisms for sharing risks."

The plan's most technically specific section covers industrial base reconstruction: breakthroughs in fundamental processes and materials; landmark machinery including high-end CNC machine tools, large LNG carriers, and the CR450 high-speed train. Particularly notable is the procurement

Industrial policy should be temporary, buying time while fundamentals are built, ideally within a decade. China's planning tradition recognises no such sunset

policy requiring state buyers to adopt domestically produced advanced equipment even when imports are available. No market for high-end domestic capital goods develops without guaranteed initial demand. This is precisely what a World Bank policy research report published last month, by Ana Margarida Fernandes and Tristan Reed, calls "public procurement to incentivize quality improvement and innovation by local suppliers", one of the sharper instruments in their taxonomy of 15 industrial policy tools.

SCORES EXCEPTIONALLY HIGH

That report is worth pausing on. Reviewing the growth strategies of 183 economies, Fernandes and Reed find that all of them target at least one industry. Industrial policy is universal. What differs is sophistication, and the three national characteristics that determine what a government can plausibly deploy: the size of its domestic market, its administrative capacity, and its fiscal space.

On all three, China scores exceptionally high, making it one of the very few economies that can legitimately reach for the full toolkit. Most developing-country governments resort to the bludgeon of sweeping tariffs and subsidies when they should use the scalpel of industrial parks, skills programmes, and procurement policy. China's 15th Plan is broadly reaching for the scalpel.

Its ambitions are ordered on a rather different scale. Which raises the question of execution. Between 2016

and 2020, China eliminated roughly 150 million tonnes of crude steel capacity and shut down all illegal ground-strip steel producers, thousands of them, by administrative direction, within months in 2017. Coal capacity fell by over 800 million tonnes in the same period. The mechanism, when central objectives are aligned and local employment pressures manageable, demonstrably functions. The current overcapacity in electric vehicles and solar panels (sectors the 15th Plan itself identifies as suffering from involutionary competition) shows precisely where it breaks down: when provincial governments protect payrolls that Beijing wants to rationalise.

Fernandes and Reed make one further point worth noting. Industrial policy should be temporary, buying time while fundamentals are built, ideally within a decade. China's planning tradition recognises no such sunset. Each five-year plan begets the next. Whether permanent planning can sustain the discipline that temporary interventions sometimes achieve is a question the 15th Plan does not engage.

The plan targets per capita GDP at levels of moderately developed countries by 2035. The compound arithmetic is not difficult. Getting the industrial policy right, sector by sector, is a different order of problem entirely.

Kautilya's Superintendent of Metals was accountable to the king. Modern planners are accountable to targets. Whether the targets remain accountable to reality is always the harder question.

Sinha writes on macroeconomics and geopolitics

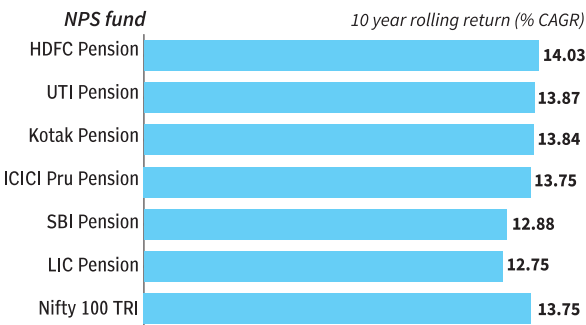
STATISTALK.

Compiled Dhuraivel Gunasekaran | Graphic Visveswaran V

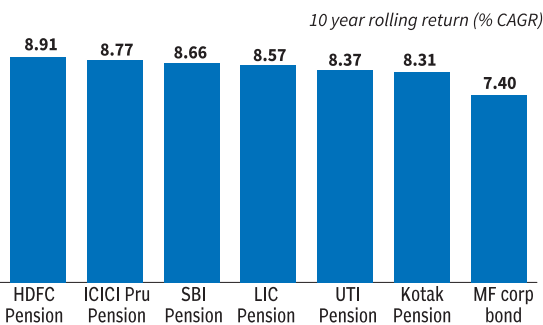
NPS funds consistency check: what 10-year rolling returns reveal

The National Pension System's (NPS) All Citizens model marks 17 years of growth, with AUM reaching ₹3.74 lakh crore as of March 2026. Across Tier I and Tier II, fund options have delivered strong returns since inception. A 10-year rolling return analysis shows equity funds generated average annualised returns of 13.5% (Tier I) and 13.4% (Tier II), slightly trailing the Nifty 100 TRI's 13.8%. In debt categories, Fund C (corporate bonds) delivered 8.6%, outperforming comparable mutual fund corporate bond fund categories. Fund G (government securities) returned 8.8%, ahead of gilt fund category averages of 7.5%.

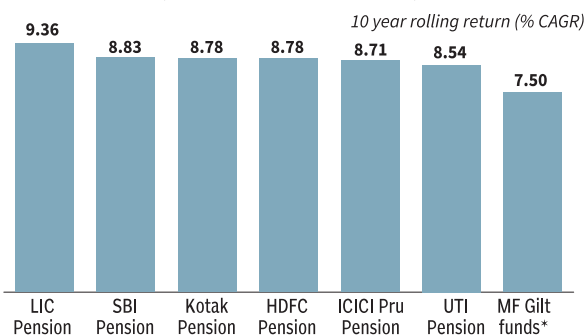
Tier-I: Fund - E (Equity)



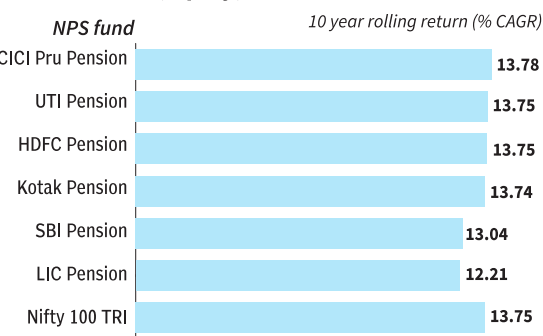
Tier-I: Fund - C (Corporate Bonds)



Tier-I: Fund - G (Government Securities)



Tier-II: Fund - E (Equity)



Rolling return data is calculated using NAV values from July 2, 2013 onward. Alternative Assets (Fund A) are excluded due to an insufficient track record for inclusion in the analysis. Category averages for mutual fund corporate bond funds and gilt funds categories are used. Values are as of March 31, 2026. Source: Respective NPS websites.

thehindubusinessline.

TWENTY YEARS AGO TODAY.

April 8, 2006

Export target set at \$120 b

Unveiling a slew of measures to put Indian exports on a higher growth trajectory and create greater employment opportunities, the Commerce and Industry Minister, Mr Kamal Nath, set a 20 per cent merchandise export growth target (about \$120 billion) for 2006-07.

Rlys withdraws telescopic fares

Even though the AC I and AC II class train fares for passengers were reduced from April 1, there is another segment of passengers who now would have to pay much higher rates — those whose journey between origin and destination involves travel in two different trains. This is because Railways used to charge telescopic charges for the entire distance in such cases, which it has now withdrawn, explained an official.

Clause 49: SEBI warns erring cos

The SEBI will ensure that tough action is taken against companies that fail to comply with Clause 49 provision of the listing agreement, according to the SEBI Chairman, Mr M. Damodaran. Among other things, Clause 49 stipulates boards of listed companies should have 50 per cent independent directors.

On businessline.in

Is EU's CBAM discriminatory?

Its compatibility with WTO law remains widely disputed. Many countries have challenged the legality of CBAM, characterising it as a protectionist measure disguised as climate action, says **Shashank Patel**

<https://tinyurl.com/yd24f726>

Freebies will hit Tamil Nadu's fiscal health

Given the serious impact on States' fisc, a judicial or legislative clampdown on such schemes has become a necessity, argues **V Kumaraswamy**

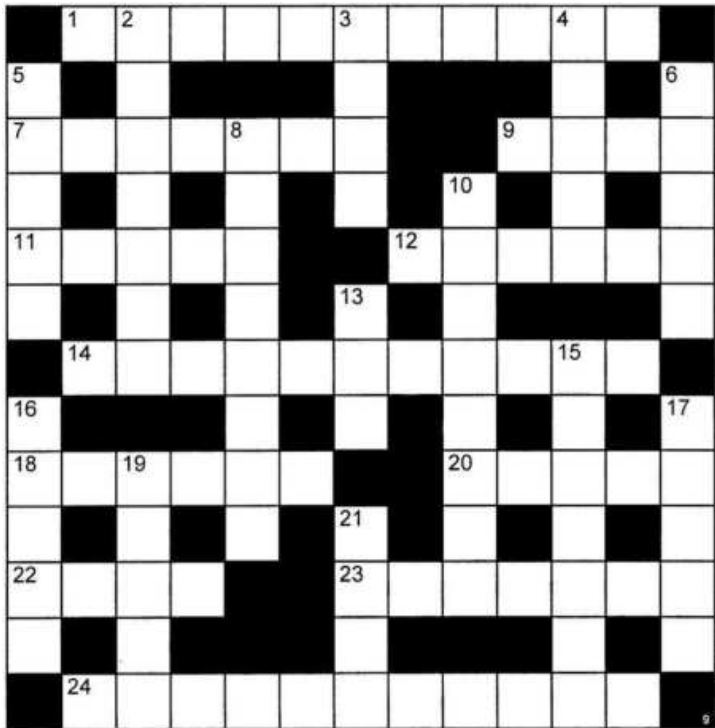
<https://tinyurl.com/3etrzdu4>

Close the backdoor in tobacco FDI policy

India prohibiting FDI in tobacco is correct and well-judged. But loopholes allow indirect participation, compromising the integrity of the policy, says **Ranganath Tannir**

<https://tinyurl.com/5mw28kt>

BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2653



EASY

ACROSS

- Union official (4,7)
- Began again (7)
- Old (4)
- Once more (5)
- Soft sort of colour (6)
- What makes one the being one is (11)
- Sounded like clockwork (6)
- Beethoven's 'Choral' symphony (5)
- Work for money (4)
- Amount paid to mail (7)
- Flipping game (11)

DOWN

- One taken for ransom (7)
- Movement of water (4)
- Correct (5)
- Fracture (5)
- Curiously (5)
- Man of the church (8)
- Metal boundary (8)
- Unit number (3)
- Short, broad-headed nail (7)
- Mount - fiery! (5)
- Impudence (5)
- Dog (5)
- Agile, nimble (4)

NOT SO EASY

ACROSS

- Not, however, a small store manager in the union (4,7)
- Start of enormous amount, when in the red, taken up again (7)
- How old Annie gets ever-diminishing starts (4)
- A profit -- and not for the first time! (5)
- Sort of colour adhesive applied to end of wall (6)
- Relays point to change, this being what one projects of self (11)
- Was correctly marked and went like clockwork (6)
- An ordinal taken from Beethoven in this symphony (5)
- Get, through one's endeavour, near adjustment (4)
- Mail: how long it takes, and what one must pay for it (7)
- Somewhat tipsy, lets eyelid droop: what a flipping game! (11)

DOWN

- Kidnappers's victim recognised by label in stockings (7)
- Being affected by the moon, it turns up in some ditches (4)
- Correct, or make it so (5)
- Between lessons, cure the habit (5)
- Curiously uneven, lumpy first and last (5)
- One in government to give attentive service to (8)
- They may surround one with iron (8)
- An individual person that's singular (3)
- Nail can move zigzag (7)
- A mount that can be steered without hesitation (5)
- It's pretty impudent, let's face it (5)
- American private hasn't quite the heart first to be a dog (5)
- Nimble snooper's shut to ask embarrassing questions (4)

SOLUTION: BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2652

ACROSS 1. Munificence 8. See to 9. Natural 10. Enforce 11. Avert 12. Sallow 14. Belies 18. Glint 19. Tipster 21. Verdant 23. Linen 24. Matchmakers

DOWN 1. Musters 2. Needful 3. Flour 4. Canter 5. Nitrate 6. Err 7. Pilot 13. Outcast 15. Intense 16. Strands 17. Stitch 18. Gives 20. Polka 22. Rum

QUICKLY.

Tata Small Cap Fund to accept inflows



New Delhi: Tata Mutual Fund announced the resumption of all fresh inflows through lump sum and switch-in applications for the Tata Small Cap Fund, effective April 6. The fund house had earlier restricted lump sum inflows to manage liquidity and capital deployment within the small-cap segment. “Our decision to resume subscriptions reflects our ability to identify businesses with strong balance sheets and sustainable growth trajectories. While volatility is inherent to this category, the recent correction has created a window to build positions at more sensible entry points for potential long-term compounding,” Anand Vardarajan, Chief Business Officer, Tata Asset Management, said.

Om Power Transmission to raise ₹150 crore via IPO

Mumbai: Om Power Transmission, a power transmission infrastructure EPC company, plans to raise ₹150 crore. It will offer 85.75 lakh shares — fresh issuance of 75.75 lakh shares and an OFS of up to 10 lakh shares, priced at ₹166-175 a share. The anchor bidding opens on Wednesday and bidding for retail and other investors on Thursday. The proceeds will help fund capex requirements, repayment of borrowings, long-term working capital and general corporate purposes. Beeline Capital Advisors will be the book-running lead manager to the offer, while MUFG Intime India has been appointed as the registrar.

FPIs pulled out ₹60,655 crore in financial services during March

IN EXIT MODE. Foreign portfolio investors’ selling deepens in auto, realty sectors, but moderates in IT stocks

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) continued selling heavily in financial services in March, touching a record level of ₹60,655 crore, though the selling moderated in the second fortnight to ₹28,824 crore, compared to ₹31,831 crore in the first fortnight, according to NSDL data released on Tuesday. The pace of FPIs selling in automobile and realty sectors intensified in the second fortnight with outflows of ₹7,691 crore and ₹2,560 crore respectively compared to ₹4,807 crore and ₹2,133 crore logged in the first fortnight of March. However, selling by FPIs almost halved in IT stocks at

₹611 crore (₹1,263 crore). The outflow from construction and consumer services sectors also increased multi-fold to ₹6,179 crore (₹2,975 crore) and ₹2,672 crore (₹531 crore). FPIs reduced their investment further in FMCG companies with the outflow increasing to ₹3,016 crore (₹2,403 crore), the data showed.

MASSIVE SELLING Abhishek Saraf, Lead Equity Strategist, Motilal Oswal Financial Services, said FPI flows had been volatile. While they turned positive in February with \$1.7 billion of inflows, the onset of the Iran war sparked another bout of massive selling of \$14.2 billion in March, taking the outflows to \$15.8 billion in 2026.

FPIs on a selling spree

	Assets under custody (₹ cr)		
	March 2025	Dec 2025	March 2026
Financial Services	21,29,116	23,89,347	19,04,718
Information Technology	5,99,150	5,38,053	3,92,065
Oil, Gas & Consumable Fuels	4,68,014	5,69,225	4,91,929
Healthcare	4,64,636	4,72,211	4,44,362
Automobile and Auto Components	4,50,940	5,75,593	4,70,436
Fast Moving Consumer Goods	3,67,799	3,67,282	2,92,189
Capital Goods	3,25,458	4,16,039	4,12,227
Telecommunication	3,21,006	4,26,989	3,43,422
Consumer Services	2,71,960	2,95,940	2,24,138
Power	2,56,428	2,37,346	2,37,583

Source: NSDL

Once the war dust settles, there is a high likelihood of a better FPI flow environment and even an abatement in outflows will be taken positively by the market. Full-blown positive flows can lead to sharper rallies, he added. After a recent correc-

tion of 10 per cent since the start of the war, valuations have become much more sober with the Nifty trading at 18 times (a 14 per cent discount to the Long period average of 20.9 times). The Indian market has dipped 3 per cent, while the

MSCI EM has risen 31 per cent, resulting in an under-performance of 34 per cent in FY26. This is the most severe underperformance over the last two decades. The Indian market’s valuation premium versus Emerging Markets have shrunk to 27 per cent against a 10-year average of 73 per cent, said Motilal Oswal Financial Services.

ASSETS DIP

The assets under custody (AUC) of FPIs have plunged 16 per cent to ₹62.46 lakh crore as of March-end against ₹74.76 lakh crore in December-end.

AUC of IT and financial services dipped 27 per cent and 21 per cent to ₹3.92 lakh crore (₹5.38 lakh crore) and ₹19.04 lakh crore (₹23.89 lakh crore).

Nifty reclaims 23,000 as IT leads four-session rally

Anupama Ghosh
Mumbai

The markets closed higher for the fourth consecutive session on Tuesday, with the Nifty 50 recovering from a weak opening to reclaim the psychologically-significant 23,000 mark. The Sensex gained 509.73 points to settle at 74,616.58, while the Nifty added 155.40 points to close at 23,123.65.

The session was anything but smooth. Both indices opened with a gap-down, with the Nifty sliding to an intra-day low near 22,719 before buyers stepped in decisively. The recovery was driven largely by short-covering and selective accumulation in IT, metals and realty, rather than broad-based buying conviction.

IT STANDS OUT

IT stocks were the standout performers of the session, with the Nifty IT index gain-

ing 2.5 per cent. Wipro led sectoral gains, following a large long-term deal announcement, reinforcing earnings visibility ahead of the Q4 results season. The sector also benefited from currency tailwinds, as the rupee appreciated against the dollar, trading near the 92.9-mark. Hindalco was the second-biggest gainer, while Dr Reddy’s and IndiGo ended as the top laggards.

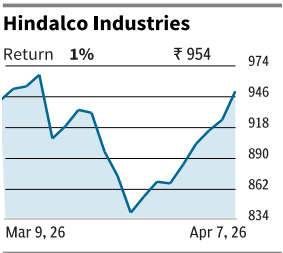
The metals index rose 1.5 per cent and realty added 1.7 per cent, with selective value buying emerging in beaten-down cyclical. However, PSU banks and Consumer Durables were the only sectoral indices to end in the red, reflecting patchy participation across the market.

Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments, said, “Gains remained largely confined to IT, FMCG and metals, while the broader market breadth stayed weak, reflecting persistent caution.”

JPMorgan upgrade lifts Hindalco

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Hindalco Industries shares surged on Tuesday after global brokerage JPMorgan upgraded the stock to “overweight” from “neutral” and raised its target price, triggering strong investor interest in the metals major. The stock rose as much as 4 per cent to ₹964.90 and closed at ₹954.50. JPMorgan expects substantial earnings growth for the sector over the coming quarters, driven by higher London Metal Exchange aluminium prices and favourable currency movements, particularly the depreciation of the Indian rupee. According to the broker-



age, these commodity tailwinds could help ease concerns around debt while also making current valuations attractive. It highlighted that prevailing stock prices for Hindalco and its peer Vedanta imply an aluminium price of around \$2,900 per tonne, significantly below the current spot level of about \$3,500 per tonne. JPMorgan also pointed to improving fundamentals in

Hindalco’s downstream business, stating that earnings at Novelis have likely bottomed out.

Q4 PREVIEW

According to Axis Securities, Hindalco is expected to report a mixed Q4 performance, with consolidated revenue likely to grow 15 per cent y-o-y and 12 per cent q-o-q driven by stronger aluminium prices, even as volumes remain subdued. Margins are expected to contract on a yearly basis, with Novelis EBITDA per tonne declining around 10 per cent. JPMorgan added that the risk-reward profile has turned favourable for Vedanta as well, upgrading it to overweight and raising the target to ₹850 from ₹680.

Jubilant Food slumps 10.5% on muted outlook

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

Shares of Jubilant FoodWorks slipped sharply on Tuesday after it indicated muted like-for-like growth for its Domino’s India business in the March quarter. Its stock tanked 10.54 per cent to settle at ₹412.70 on the BSE on Tuesday. During the day, it dropped 11.15 per cent to ₹409.85 — the 52-week low level.

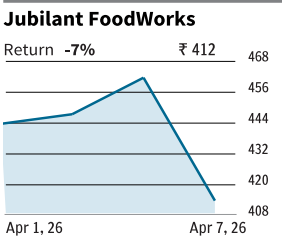
Analysts said that the ongoing commercial LPG supply constraints could be one of the key reasons for the muted performance, given it had posted mid-single digit like-for-like growth in Q3. The company had recorded 5

per cent like-for-like growth for Domino’s India business in the December quarter.

In an investor presentation released in February, the company stated that Domino’s India business had, on average, posted a like-for-like growth of 5.5 per cent over the past 10 years.

REVENUE GROWTH

In its Q4FY26 provisional business update, Jubilant FoodWorks said its consolidated revenue from operations from the March quarter grew 19.1 per cent year-on-year, while standalone revenue from operations grew 6.2 per cent. The leading food services companies in a BSE filing added that the like-for-like growth for Dom-



ino’s India for the March quarter grew marginally at 0.2 per cent.

“During the quarter, 69 stores were added to the JFL group network, taking the total store count to 3,663. Domino’s India added 59 new stores during the period, ending the quarter with 2,455 stores,” it stated. Analysts said that the slower performance was be-

low expectations. In an analyst note, Karan Taurani, EVP, Elara Securities, said, “The weakness appears largely attributable to ongoing commercial LPG supply constraints, given that nearly 95 per cent of its outlets are LPG-dependent.

In our view, this is likely the primary driver of the miss, rather than any structural demand weakness, especially as competitive intensity in the pizza category continues to moderate.”

Abneesh Roy, Executive Director, NuVama Institutional Equities, noted shortage of commercial LPG due to the ongoing West Asia conflict could also be one of the reasons for slower growth.

Will SEBI’s reset revive social stock exchanges?

bl.explainer

Akshata Gorde
Mumbai

From a bold attempt to marry capital markets with social impact to a platform struggling for scale, India’s SSE experiment is now getting a regulatory reboot.

What is a social stock exchange (SSE)?

A social stock exchange is a segment within existing stock exchanges that enables non-profits and social enterprises to raise funds from the public. Unlike traditional listings, these entities do not offer equity or financial returns. Instead, they raise money through instruments such as Zero Coupon Zero Principal (ZCZP) bonds, where investors contribute capital with the expectation of measurable social impact rather than monetary gains.

Why did SEBI introduce SSEs?

The idea was to formalise and deepen the funding ecosystem for social enterprises and non-profits. India’s social sector has historically relied on grants, CSR funding, and philanthropy, often with limited transparency and



What are the key relaxations announced by SEBI?

In a bid to revive activity, SEBI has significantly eased norms. It has reduced the minimum investment size to ₹1,000 from ₹2 lakh, lowered the minimum subscription requirement for fundraising, and extended the validity period for non-profits to remain registered without raising funds. The regulator has also streamlined compliance through a consolidated master circular, simplifying disclosure and procedural requirements.

Will these changes make a difference?

The relaxations are expected to improve accessibility and participation. Lower ticket sizes could bring in retail donors, while easier fundraising norms may help more non-profits successfully raise capital. However, the core challenge remains, the lack of financial returns means SSEs will depend on a niche base of impact-focused investors. The platform’s long-term success will hinge on building credible impact measurement frameworks and widening awareness around impact investing, said experts.

fragmented access to capital. By bringing such entities under a regulated market framework, SEBI aimed to improve disclosure standards, build trust among donors and create a scalable platform for impact investing.

Why hasn’t the platform seen meaningful traction?

Adoption has been slow due to a mix of structural and regulatory challenges. Compliance requirements, such as detailed disclosures and impact reporting, have been seen as onerous for smaller NGOs.

On the investor side, the absence of financial returns has limited participation. Additionally, earlier norms such as a ₹2-lakh minimum investment threshold restricted retail involvement, while delays in approvals and execution further dampened momentum.

SpaceX lays out IPO plans, eyes June roadshow

Reuters
New York

SpaceX outlined details of its highly-anticipated IPO at a meeting with its team of bankers on Monday night, telling them it plans to earmark a large portion of shares for retail investors and will host 1,500 of them at an event in June following the IPO roadshow launch, according to two people familiar with the matter.

“Retail is going to be a critical part of this and a bigger part than any IPO in history,” Chief Financial Officer Bret Johnsen said during the virtual meeting, the two people said, asking not to be identi-

fied because the discussion was private. Johnsen said the large retail component is by design as “those are folks that have been incredibly supportive of us and of Elon (Musk) for a long time, and we want to make sure that we recognise that.”

Reuters reported last month that SpaceX is rewriting the IPO play-book with a large retail portion in the offering.

\$75-BILLION IPO

The meeting brought together the full syndicate for the first time as part of the process for what is expected to be the biggest initial public offering ever, as the rocket maker seeks to raise \$75 billion, valu-

ing SpaceX at as much as \$1.75 trillion, Reuters has previously reported.

The Elon Musk-led company plans to launch its roadshow the week of June 8, when executives and bankers will pitch the IPO to investors, the people said. About 125 financial analysts from the 21 banks on the deal are scheduled to meet with the company the day before, they added. On June 11, SpaceX plans to host 1,500 retail investors at what the people described as a major investor event.

The company plans to make its IPO prospectus public in late May, they said.

SpaceX did not immediately respond to a request for comment.

BROKER’S CALL.

JM Financial

JSW INFRASTRUCTURE (BUY)

Target: ₹365
CMP: ₹234.25
The recent West Asia crisis has affected JSW Infrastructure, as its Fujairah liquid storage tankage was hit by drone attacks. However, we expect its FY26 EBITDA guidance of ₹2,600 crore to be largely met despite disruptions at Fujairah on the back of a strong performance for group-linked cargo and continuing scale-up in the logistic business. Furthermore, with potential plan for a primary-raise announced by the company to meet minimum public shareholding norms, we expect leverage to remain significantly below 2.5x (net debt/EBITDA) over FY26-28E, thereby supporting the company’s growth capex plan. We are trimming FY27-28 estimates building in the fallout from West Asia. We forecast Q4FY26 EBITDA would be ₹743 crore despite some impact from the West Asia crisis. There may be some disruptions in steel-grade limestone imports from the region in our view. That said, these factors may be offset by strong group cargo performance (led by rising steel prices and production), improved outlook for the coastal coal movement and logistical (Navkar) ramp-up. We expect strong growth till FY30E (EBITDA exceeding ₹8,000 crore) as the recently-commissioned capacities and logistics ramp-up and further port capacities at Keni (targeting Vijayanagar Steel Plant cargo) and Oman come on stream. Despite minimal EBITDA revisions, our DCF-based TP is revised down to ₹365 (from ₹400), also factoring in rising G-Sec yields; maintain BUY.

Choice Institutional Equities

LEELA PALACES (BUY)

Target: ₹510
CMP: ₹414.45
Leela Palaces Hotels & Resorts, majority-owned by Brookfield, operates as an institutionally-owned pure-play luxury hospitality platform. The company has a portfolio of five owned palace hotels across Udaipur, Jaipur, Chennai, Bengaluru and Delhi, along with eight managed luxury properties across key urban and leisure markets. As of end-M1FY26, the company operated 3,544 luxury keys. It has commenced its first international expansion with investment in a Dubai luxury hotel, adding about 546 keys (including 182 residence keys) and an acquisition of a resort in Coorg adding 71 keys, taking its total current inventory to about 4,161 keys. It has a strong pipeline of about 1,008 hotel keys, and 38 keys under development at Udaipur, 19 keys at Coorg and about 245 branded residences across Dubai and Mumbai. It follows a hybrid growth strategy, expanding its owned portfolio, while adding keys through capital-light management contracts, supporting disciplined capital allocation. We initiate coverage on Leela Hotels with a Buy rating and an FY28E EV/Adj. EBITDA of 18.0x to arrive at a TP of ₹510, implying an upside potential of 22.3 per cent. We expect revenue and EBITDA to expand at a CAGR of 16.9 per cent and 18.2 per cent respectively over FY26E-29E.

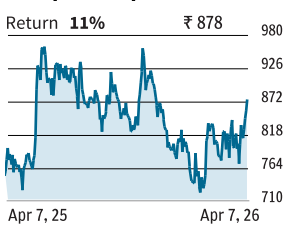
businessline is not responsible for the recommendations sourced from third party brokerages. Reports may be sent to: blmarketwatch@gmail.com

TODAY’S PICK.

Welspun Corp (₹788.85): BUY

Gurumurthy K
bl. research bureau

Welspun Corp



The short-term outlook is bullish for Welspun Corp. The stock has been moving up well for more than two weeks now. The 2 per cent rise on Tuesday has taken the share price well above the 200-Day Moving Average (DMA). Immediate support is at ₹867. Below that, ₹850, the 200-DMA, is the next important support. Moving average crossovers on the daily chart also strengthens the bullish case. Welspun Corp share price can rise to ₹960 and even ₹990 in the coming weeks.

Traders can buy Welspun Corp shares now at ₹879. Accumulate on dips at ₹868.

Keep the stop-loss at ₹822 initially. Trail the stop-loss up to ₹886 as soon as the stock goes up to ₹898. Revise the stop-loss higher to ₹910 and ₹945 when the price touches ₹940 and ₹960 respectively. Exit the long positions at ₹980.

Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading

Day trading guide

23165 » Nifty 50 Futures

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
23050	22870	23285	23450	Go long on dips at 23080. Stop-loss can be placed at 22980

₹772 » HDFC Bank

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
761	758	775	781	Go long only above 775. Keep the stop-loss at 773

₹1340 » Infosys

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1320	1310	1365	1385	Go long on dips at 1330. Keep the stop-loss at 1305

₹299 » ITC

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
297	294	301	304	Wait for a rise. Go short at 300 with a stop-loss at 302

₹286 » ONGC

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
284	281	290	293	Go long on dips at 285. Stop-loss can be kept at 283

₹1307 » Reliance Ind.

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1290	1265	1315	1330	Take fresh shorts below 1290. Keep the stop-loss at 1295

₹1027 » SBI

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1015	995	1040	1065	Go short on a rise at 1035. Keep the stop-loss at 1045

₹2541 » TCS

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
2510	2480	2590	2625	Go long on dips at 2530 and 2520. Keep the stop-loss at 2505

S1, S2: Support 1 & 2; R1, R2: Resistance 1 & 2.

Nifty 50 Movers					▲ 155.40 pts.
	Close(F)	Pts	PE	WN(%)	
Infosys	1339.40	25.39	19.40	4.43	
Bharti Airtel	1830.30	25.11	30.10	5.30	
ICICI Bank	1245.50	21.99	15.75	8.40	
TCS	2539.80	14.68	19.16	2.45	
HCL Tech	1441.60	8.82	23.75	1.44	
Hindalco	954.50	8.54	13.34	1.30	
ITC	298.45	7.57	18.06	2.71	
Sun Pharma	1718.00	5.41	37.63	1.72	
Hind Unilever	2110.60	4.99	49.32	1.77	
Wipro	204.72	4.63	16.11	0.55	
ONGC	286.65	4.07	8.02	1.05	
Kotak Bank	362.95	3.85	19.21	2.52	
JSW Steel	1151.90	3.74	36.27	1.02	
Tata Steel	198.13	3.66	27.12	1.55	
HDFC Bank	772.00	3.34	15.35	11.15	
Tech Mahindra	1473.40	3.31	31.44	0.88	
Maruti Suzuki	1279.00	3.15	26.95	1.58	
Axis Bank	1250.10	3.00	14.71	3.38	
NTPC	368.85	2.84	14.41	1.65	
Bajaj Auto	9049.50	2.59	28.47	0.95	
Bajaj Finance	855.10	2.48	29.04	2.16	
Coal India	463.00	1.71	9.59	0.99	
Bajaj Finserv	1684.40	1.52	14.94	0.92	
NestleIndia	1222.80	1.06	72.29	0.83	
TataConsumerProduct	1062.00	0.97	71.42	0.65	
Shriram Finance Ltd.	930.65	0.81	19.14	1.23	
Tata Motors PV	308.70	0.59	41.98	0.61	
Grasim Ind	2621.00	0.55	18.83	0.94	
Bharti Elec	427.80	0.51	52.44	1.45	
SBI Life	1914.40	0.46	74.50	0.78	
HDFC Life	581.70	0.30	66.40	0.59	
Eicher Motors	6605.50	0.29	33.82	0.86	
PowerGrid Corp	295.40	0.25	17.70	1.26	
Asian Paints	2186.20	0.19	53.63	0.93	
Cipla	1202.40	0.18	21.43	0.64	
Max Healthcare	632.40	0.13	63.93	0.65	
Jio Financial Services Ltd.	225.33	0.01	93.16	0.73	
Reliance Ind	1304.60	-0.15	18.06	8.31	
Eternal Ltd.	231.97	-0.36	96.09	0.58	
UltraTech Cement	10936.00	-0.49	12.22	1.22	
Trent Ltd.	382.00	-0.51	83.90	0.80	
Adani Ports	1381.00	-0.98	25.46	0.96	
Apollo Hosp	732.05	-1.04	56.46	0.71	
L&T	3772.30	-1.13	26.99	4.12	
Adani Enter	1882.10	-1.14	15.37	0.46	
Adani Green	1420.60	-1.40	13.31	0.45	
State Bank	1030.40	-2.13	10.99	4.03	
Int'lComate	426.80	-2.16	51.40	0.91	
Dr Reddys Lab	1196.10	-2.88	18.08	0.69	
M&M	3006.00	-2.92	22.12	2.53	

● FOCUS ON KERALA

From ₹218 cr to just ₹84, stark wealth gap among candidates

LEGAL DISCLOSURE. 324 candidates have criminal cases, with 201 facing serious charges

Yashaswani Chauhan
New Delhi

As Kerala heads into the Assembly elections, an analysis of 863 candidates across 140 constituencies shows a wide gap between the wealthiest nominees and those with minimal declared assets.

A former Nationalist Congress Party-Sharadchandra Pawar (NCP-SP) leader who joined the Kerala Congress in 2024, Reji Cheriyan

DATA FOCUS.

emerged as the wealthiest candidate with total declared assets of over ₹218 crore. His wealth is overwhelmingly driven by immovable assets valued at ₹210.05 crore and movable assets worth ₹8.91 crore. A substantial portion of his portfolio comprises commercial buildings worth ₹200 crore.

Cheriyan has also declared agricultural and non-agricultural lands and a residential property. His movable assets include bank deposits exceeding ₹6 crore, jewellery worth nearly ₹40 lakh and an extensive fleet of vehicles —

from luxury cars such as Mercedes-Benz and Land Rover — to houseboats and speedboats.

BJP CANDIDATE
Chenkal Rajasekharan, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) candidate from Neyyattinkara, follows next with total assets of ₹116 crore. His disclosures show sizeable investments in shares of hospitality and estate companies, accounting for nearly ₹79 crore of his movable wealth.

A hotelier, businessman and educationist, Rajasekharan also owns agricultural land, commercial buildings and residential properties across Kerala, Tamil Nadu and Mumbai, taking his immovable assets to ₹33.74 crore.

Rajeev Chandrasekhar, senior BJP leader and State President of the BJP in Kerala, figures among the top three with total assets of ₹111 crore. An entrepreneur-turned-politician, he founded BPL Mobile in 1994, one of India's early cellular networks.

Chandrasekhar's movable assets amount to ₹96.91 crore and an immovable

Nearly half of all candidates (46 per cent) are graduates or above, while total women candidates are 92

property valued at ₹15.07 crore in Bengaluru. His wealth is largely investment-driven, spanning shares, mutual funds, bonds and loans extended to business entities.

Other candidates in the wealthiest list include Shibu Thekkumpuram and P V Anvar, each with assets exceeding ₹65 crore.

PUBLIC SUPPORT
At the opposite end of the spectrum is Ashna Thambi, a 26-year-old Socialist Unity Centre of India (Communist) candidate from Ettumanoor, who declared total assets of just ₹84 (₹40 in cash and ₹44 in bank account) with no immovable property.

Thambi stated she is a full-time party worker from a modest family and relies on

public support for campaign funds. Others with minimal declared wealth include Thampi Kavumpadam and Karthika Devi M (₹500 each), and Sooraj K and Rajan M (₹1,500 each), all without immovable assets.

businessline's analysis shows that the BJP has the highest number of ₹20 crore-plus candidates, with six nominees in this bracket.

Among other parties, the Indian National Congress (INC) follows next with four such candidates. Kerala Congress and Kerala Congress (M) have two each.

Indian Union Muslim League, the Revolutionary Socialist Party and the Kerala Congress (Jacob) have one each.

CRIMINAL CASES
Of the 863 candidates analysed, criminal disclosures show that 324 candidates (38 per cent) have declared criminal cases against them, with 201 candidates facing serious charges.

Nearly half of all candidates (46 per cent) are graduates or above, while total women candidates are 92, comprising 11 per cent of the total field.

Passport claims, police action mark final days before elections in Assam

Our Bureau
New Delhi

With polling in Assam scheduled in just two days, the campaign has taken a dramatic turn with police action and personal barbs dominating headlines as a team of the Assam police landed on Tuesday at the Delhi residence of Congress spokesperson Pawan Khera.

The visit comes amid an escalating face-off with Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma after Khera targeted the CM's wife, Riniki Bhuyan Sarma, at a press conference using colourful imagery reminiscent of the popular caper film *Bunty Aur Babli* while presenting what he described as documents relating to alleged foreign assets.

At the press conference, Khera launched a series of pointed attacks, saying: "Himanta Biswa Sarma's entire politics is predicated on hatred against Muslims; yet, his wife holds passports from two Muslim countries."

He further asked: "Are they making preparations to flee the country in the event of an electoral defeat?"

FOREIGN ASSETS
Khera also alleged non-disclosure of foreign assets, stating: "Many people own properties abroad; however, when a spouse contests an election, these assets must be disclosed in their affidavit. Yet, there is no mention whatsoever of these two Dubai properties in Himanta Biswa Sarma's affidavit."



FUTILE ATTEMPT. Assam police seen exiting Pawan Khera's residence in New Delhi on Tuesday SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

ALLEGATIONS REFUTED
The allegations were firmly rejected by Riniki Bhuyan Sarma, who announced legal action, saying: "I expected a spokesperson of a national party to exercise basic due diligence, rather than circulate poorly fabricated images of imaginary passports and documents. I will now be letting the law take over. Criminal charges are being initiated. We can continue this in court."

The Chief Minister responded with a sharp political counterattack as the campaign rhetoric intensified.

"Today's press conference by Pawan Khera reflects the deep frustration and panic within the Congress party. As Assam moves decisively towards a historic mandate, such desperate and baseless attacks only expose their sinking ground," he said.

Escalating his rhetoric further, Sarma declared: "I categorically reject every allegation made by him. These are malicious, fabricated and politically motivated lies aimed at misleading the people of Assam."

Tuesday's police action added another dramatic layer to the confrontation. The Assam police, accompanied by the Delhi police, searched Khera's Nizamuddin East residence, but did not find him at home.

Congress sources said Khera was in Hyderabad, prompting Sarma to allege that "he ran away from Guwahati yesterday... I have come to know through the media that the police have gone to his residence in Delhi, but he has run away to Hyderabad. The law will take its own course."

After the search, an Assam police officer said, "We did not find Pawan Khera. The house was searched. Some objectionable documents were recovered."

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● STATE OF PLAY

It's DMK vs AIADMK again, but Vijay enters the fray as wildcard in TN polls

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai

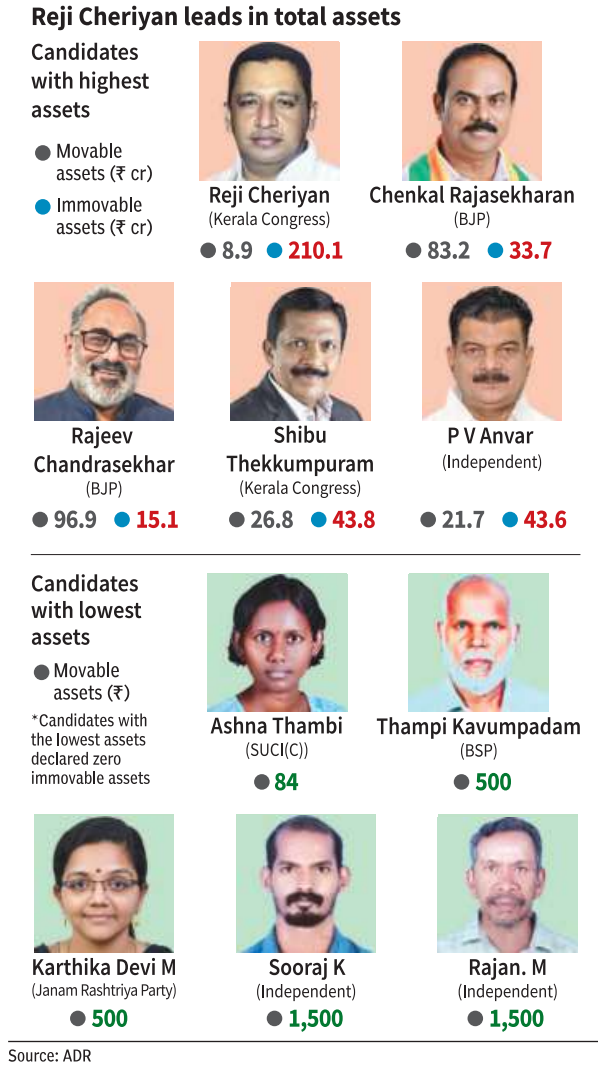
The battlelines for the Tamil Nadu Assembly elections are once again drawn between the two dominant Dravidian forces — the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) and the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) — which have collectively ruled the State for over five decades.

Yet, this election carries an element of unpredictability, with actor-turned-politician C Joseph Vijay and his fledgling Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) emerging as a potential disruptor, particularly among the youth.

Vijay's rallies have been drawing large crowds, especially first-time voters and women. This has raised concerns within both Dravidian camps about a possible split in their traditional support bases. While it remains unclear whether this enthusiasm will translate into votes, his presence has added a new dimension to what has largely been a bipolar contest.

Historically, Tamil Nadu has rarely voted an incumbent government back to power. The last notable exception came in 2016, when J Jayalalithaa led the AIADMK to a historic consecutive victory, becoming the first Chief Minister since her mentor MG Ramachandran in 1984 to achieve the feat.

DRAVIDIAN MODEL
The DMK is aggressively



QUICKLY.

‘No exit polls from April 9 to April 29’

New Delhi: Exit polls can neither be held nor disseminated from 7 am of April 9 till 6.30 pm of April 29 for the five Assembly elections taking place this month, said the Election Commission. It has also cautioned that conducting or broadcasting exit polls in the period is violative of section 126A of the Representation of the People Act, 1951, and is “punishable with imprisonment up to a period of two years, or with fine or both”.

While Kerala, Assam and Puducherry are going for Assembly polls on April 9, the electoral exercise will be held in Tamil Nadu on April 23. In West Bengal, the polls will be held on April 23 and 29. While the 48-hour ‘silence period’ in Kerala and Puducherry will commence at 6 pm on Tuesday, it will kick in at 5 pm in Assam. **■**



Strong show of support by BJP's national leaders

Chennai: In a show of support to BJP candidates in Tamil Nadu, some of the party's top national leaders, including Chief Ministers of BJP-ruled States, flew down to accompany candidates while they filed their nomination papers.

Leading the list was Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnis who flew down to Madurai to accompany Ramaa Srinivasan (Madurai South). Piyush Goyal (in picture), who is the party in-charge for Tamil Nadu, accompanied Tamilisai Soundararajan in Mylapore.

Bhajan Lal Sharma, Chief Minister of Rajasthan, flew to Coimbatore to accompany Vanathi Srinivasan (Coimbatore North). Interestingly, former State President K Annamalai was also present when she filed the nomination. **OUR BUREAU**



‘Himanta should tender unconditional apology’

New Delhi: The Congress on Tuesday accused Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma of insulting party chief Mallikarjun Kharge and demanded an unconditional apology from him for his “deplorable conduct”, saying it reflects the “anti-Dalit mindset” of the BJP. Congress General Secretary KC Venugopal said by using words like ‘mad man’ for Kharge, Sarma had insulted one of the tallest leaders of the country, who hails from a humble background. In a post on X, Venugopal said: “Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma asking ‘Kaun hai Kharge?’ and using street insults like *paagal* is deeply problematic. Himanta must apologise for “this deplorable conduct, for insulting one of the tallest leaders in our country who hails from the most humble background.” **■**

Kerala CM ‘confident’ of stronger mandate for LDF

Kannur: Kerala CPI(M) veteran and Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan struck a confident tone here on Tuesday, saying his party-led front continues to enjoy public support despite a decade in power. Drawing from his recent interactions with the public, Vijayan, who led the CPI(M)-led LDF's poll campaign, claimed that the overall mood remained favourable to the LDF.

“What we could understand from our interactions with the people here is that Kerala's mindset is with the LDF,” said Vijayan at a meet-the-press programme organised by the Kannur Press Club. “There was a rejection of the UDF at various levels,” said the CM. He went a step further, expressing confidence about the outcome.

Vijayan said the LDF will return to power with an even stronger mandate, winning more seats than it did in 2021. The LDF had won 99 seats out of a total of 140 constituencies in 2021. He also claimed that the NDA would “draw a blank” in the State. While acknowledging criticism, he stressed that it had not turned into a broader backlash. Vijayan also responded strongly to remarks made by Rahul Gandhi, who alleged a CPI(M)-BJP understanding in Kerala. Dismissing the charge, Vijayan said: “He has raised certain baseless allegations during this visit.” **■**

Kerala on razor's edge as fight between LDF and UDF goes down to the wire

Vinson Kurian
Ravi MG
Thiruvananthapuram/Thrissur

It is a pitched battle between the CPI(M)-led Left Democratic Front (LDF) and the Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) as campaigning drew to a close on Tuesday, two days ahead of polling, with both sides scrambling for every last vote in what is widely seen as a tight contest.

On the ground, the ruling LDF is relying heavily on its organisational muscle, including booth-level cadres, neighbourhood committees and long-tested election machinery to carry it through what could be its toughest test yet in seeking a third

consecutive term. Party insiders said that the strategy in the final stretch was simple: Protect the committed vote and chase the undecided. Booth squads have been deployed deep into residential pockets, fanning out through suburban and semi-urban neighbourhoods to ensure that loyal voters turn up on polling day.

“Not a single committed vote must be lost; any incremental vote is an added advantage,” said a local functionary overseeing mobilisation in suburban Thiruvananthapuram, reflecting the emphasis on turnout over persuasion.

Yet, beneath the show of confidence, vulnerabilities remain. The LDF's position appears strained in parts of



THE HEAT IS ON. Supporters of all parties assembled to celebrate in Thiruvananthapuram on Tuesday **NIRMAL HARINDRAN**

Malabar, particularly in districts where the UDF rode a wave of support in the recent local body elections. In pockets of Kannur, long seen as a Left bastion, internal dissidence has unsettled sections of the cadre, forcing leaders to spend more time firefighting than expanding support.

In Kozhikode and Malapuram, the contest has taken on a sharper political tone, with LDF insiders accusing the Congress of stoking sentiment in minority-heavy areas. A senior leader privately conceded that mobilisation in these districts had been more challenging than anticipated, especially where the UDF had fielded

strong campaigners who are drawing large crowds.

INTERNAL REBELLION
Central Kerala has thrown up another unexpected challenge — rebellion from within. Veteran CPI(M) leader G Sudhakaran's decision to step down from Amalappuzha as an Independent candidate, with tacit backing from the UDF, has unsettled what was once considered a secure red pocket. The optics of the octogenarian sharing the stage with senior Congress leaders rattled cadres who now find themselves defending territory rather than expanding it.

The UDF, sensing an opening, is projecting quiet confidence across regions. Congress workers on the

ground speak of strong traction in Malabar and steady gains in central Kerala, while also claiming that anti-incumbency in parts of the south could tilt close contests in their favour.

Still, few are willing to predict sweeping victories, acknowledging that the race remains too close to call.

Among voters, loyalty runs deep, but certainty appears thinner than in previous elections. In Thrissur district's Mangad village, 54-year-old Vibhish KK, who runs a utility services company, said his family's longstanding allegiance to the Left remains intact. “The Pinarayi Vijayan government has done exceptional work in the last 10 years, and the Communists need to be re-

warded with another term.”

Others echo support but with measured caution. Sunitha Subash, 51, from Kattakampal, said she had examined party manifestos carefully. “They are offering a lot of freebies, but I am not taken in by their promises,” she said, adding that she still believes the LDF deserves another chance.

But signs of restlessness are visible. Harish TK, 45, believes that the time may be right for a change. “In the absence of solid alternatives, the ruling party becomes complacent and remains oblivious to the needs of people,” he said, reflecting sentiments among voters exploring alternatives beyond the two dominant fronts.

Some voters remain unde-

cided, weighing local performance against broader allegations. Sajeev TR, 55, a small business owner, said the sitting MLA had delivered on some promises, but corruption allegations against the government had created disillusionment.

Others point to infrastructure gaps despite visible development. Sijini K, 29, said improvements were uneven. “The LDF is bragging about the infrastructure development, but roads connecting villages and small towns have been neglected,” she said.

As campaigning winds down, both fronts are locked in a contest where cadre strength, local equations and voter turnout could decide the outcome.

QUICKLY.

Quest Global buys India-based Bitsilica



Bengaluru: Quest Global, a pure-play engineering services company, has acquired Bitsilica, an India-based semiconductor design services company. The acquisition will strengthen Quest Global's semiconductor offerings and expand its footprint in supporting global semiconductor customers. It will also accelerate the company's strategy to build full-stack capabilities. OUR BUREAU

Visa India head Sandeep Ghosh to step Down

Visa Inc's India and South Asia head Sandeep Ghosh has resigned from his role, according to people familiar with the matter. Ghosh, who led Visa's operations across India and neighbouring South Asian countries, played a key role in expanding the company's presence in digital payments and strengthening partnerships with banks and fintech firms. BLOOMBERG

Deals, demand to help mid-tier IT firms outpace larger peers in Q4

EXTERNAL FORCE. Macro headwinds likely to keep overall sector momentum in check

Sanjana B Bengaluru

Mid-cap IT firms are quietly widening the growth gap with larger peers, leveraging sharper deal ramp-ups, vendor consolidation opportunities, and sustained demand in select verticals, even as macro headwinds keep overall sector momentum in check.

Brokerage estimates for Q4FY26 suggest a familiar pattern: muted growth for tier-1 IT firms, contrasted by relatively stronger performance among mid-tier peers.

According to a Motilal Oswal Financial Services (MOFSL) report, large-caps are likely to post sequential constant currency (cc) growth in the range of -1.0 per cent to 1.5 per cent, while mid-caps are expected to outperform once again with -0.5 per cent to 3.5 per cent growth.

Similarly, JM Financial Institutional Securities pegs mid-tier year-on-year (y-o-y) cc growth of 3 per cent to 22 per cent band, and -0.3 per cent to 3.6 per cent cc



IN LEAD. At the top end of this spectrum is Persistent Systems, which will lead the mid-cap pack, said most brokerages

quarter-on-quarter (q-o-q) growth.

PAVING THE WAY

At the top end of this spectrum is Persistent Systems, which will lead the mid-cap pack, according to a majority of brokerages.

A HSIE Research report highlights Persistent's continued strength, driven by momentum in BFSI and technology verticals, estimating 3.4 per cent q-o-q cc growth.

MOFSL also expects Persistent to achieve the highest sequential growth of around

3.5 per cent q-o-q cc growth.

This is followed by Coforge and Mphasis, who, according to a report by Equirus Securities, will trend toward the upper end of the 1.8 per cent to 3.6 per cent q-o-q cc growth range, supported by steady deal wins and ramp-ups.

BFSI DEAL

HSIE similarly forecasts 2.5 per cent growth for Mphasis, aided by strong BFSI deal traction, while MOFSL expects Coforge to deliver 1.5 per cent growth, accompanied by a 160 basis point (bps)

margin expansion as wage hike pressures ease. "We believe Coforge's strong executable order book and resilient client spending across verticals bode well for its organic business. Encora's acquisition expands its presence in the hi-tech and healthcare verticals. We continue to view Coforge as a structurally strong mid-tier player well-placed to benefit from vendor consolidation/cost-takeout deals and digital transformation," the MOFSL report noted.

Brokerages point to mid-caps benefiting from a mix of deal ramp-ups, vendor consolidation opportunities, and sustained demand in select verticals like BFSI, healthcare, and hi-tech.

Even as macro uncertainty, geopolitical tensions, and cautious client spending weigh on large deal conversions, the mid-tier cohort continues to find growth pockets through agility and execution.

In a quarter where growth is scarce, that operational edge is proving enough to keep mid-cap IT a step ahead of its larger peers.

Rupee may extend the recovery

Akhil Nallamuthu bl Research Bureau

The rupee appreciated about 0.5 per cent over the past week and closed at 92.99 against the dollar on Tuesday. The recovery indicates some stabilisation after recent volatility, although underlying risks remain.

WEEKLY RUPEE VIEW.

A key factor supporting the rupee has been the recent measures by the Reserve Bank of India, particularly the cap on banks' Net Open Position (NOP-INR). As banks continue to unwind dollar positions ahead of the April 10 deadline, supply of dollars in the market has improved, helping the local currency move away from extreme weakness.

However, external risks continue to pose challenges. Crude oil prices remain elevated, with Brent futures trading around \$110 per barrel and already up over 6 per cent so far this month. For an oil-importing country like India, sustained high crude prices can widen the current account deficit and increase dollar demand, exerting pressure on the rupee.

Foreign flows have also been unfavourable. Accord-



Crude oil prices, however, remain elevated, with Brent futures trading around \$110/barrel GETTY IMAGES

ing to NSDL data, net FPI outflows in April so far stand at \$5.4 billion, taking the year-to-date outflows to about \$18 billion.

Geopolitical tensions involving Iran continue to keep markets on edge, while investors are also closely watching the RBI's policy decision, where the repo rate is expected to remain unchanged at 5.25 per cent.

Overall, while regulatory measures have provided near-term support, global and domestic headwinds remain in play.

CHAT

The rupee has been on a recovery since early last week. While the overall trend has not reversed, the prevailing price action shows that the

upswing can extend a bit more. The nearest resistance is at 92.60, the 50 per cent Fibonacci retracement level of the prior downswing. There is a good chance for the local currency to surpass 92.60 and appreciate to 92, a notable resistance.

On the other hand, if the rupee slips from the current level of 92.99, it can find support at 93.50. Subsequent support is at 94.

While the rupee shows signs of some more recovery, the dollar index, which appreciated 2.3 per cent in March, seems to be sticking to a sideways trend. It struggles to decisively break out of the barrier at 100.50 and at the same time, it has successfully been defending the base at 99.

Note that a breakout of 100.50 by the dollar index can bring back the bearish sentiment in the rupee, leading to a fresh sell-off. Nevertheless, as it stands, the dollar index is likely to stay flat whereas the Indian currency can inch up in the upcoming sessions.

OUTLOOK

Based on the current setup, the rupee can appreciate towards 92.30-92 in the near term. That said, further gains beyond 92 may be limited due to the on-going geopolitical risks.

Pre-funding norms for biz: BCs may get some relief

K Ram Kumar Mumbai

Business Correspondents (BCs) may find some succour in RBI's proposed guidelines relating to services provided by them to banks. Banks may put in place a mechanism for progressive reduction in pre-funding (security deposit) requirements for BCs providing banking services on their behalf in the hinterland.

However, this move does not meet BCs' request for reducing the security deposit requirement upfront.

As per the draft 'Reserve Bank of India (Branch Authorisation) Amendment Directions, 2026', issued by the RBI on April 6, banks may include a provision for placing suitable transaction limits relating to transactions put through BCs. Further, they may give effect to a mechanism for progressive reduction in pre-funding requirements as an incentive mechanism based on business relationship, quality of customer service and service to under-banked areas.

Banks may also ensure that the benefit of progressive reduction in pre-funding requirements for BCs is passed on to BC sub-agents.

BCS VOICE CONCERN

Players in the BC industry voiced concerns that the Indian Banks' Association (IBA) has stipulated a high security deposit of ₹50 lakh per 1,000 customer service points/CSPs, with propor-



BCs function as critical enablers of last-mile access to financial services, particularly in respect of underserved, rural and remote locations. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTO

tional increase thereafter. This is in sharp contrast to the security deposit norm of ₹10 lakh per 1,000 CSPs (or ₹1,000 per CSP) that the State Bank of India (SBI) and few other banks have been following.

This blanket escalation creates unsustainable financial burden, especially for small, medium and emerging corporate BCs (CBCs), leading to potential exclusion of capable players from the ecosystem, the players said.

Dharanidhar Tripathy, CEO, Business Correspondent Resource Council, emphasised that the historical BC framework allowed a bank-wise flexible range of ₹1,000-₹2,500 per CSP.

Although there is a blanket indemnity given by CBCs in their agreement with banks to bear the loss due to fraud or any wrongdoing on the part of CSPs, the stipulation of ₹50 lakh security deposit for 1,000 CSPs appears to be unreasonable, unjust and unfair, he said.

Consumers prioritise convenience over price considerations: Report

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani New Delhi

Consumers are increasingly seeking speed and accessibility reflecting an evolving shift towards convenience over price considerations.

A report released by Grant Thornton Bharat on Tuesday said that convenience is emerging as the primary driver of retail choices in India as Indian consumers with more than 70 per cent of consumers saying they would continue using quick commerce platforms even if discounts were reduced.

Around 45 per cent of consumers rely on quick commerce for last-minute or urgent purchases, while 24 per cent of respondents said they use these platforms for daily top-ups such as milk

and bread. Another 19 per cent turn to quick commerce for impulse purchases, reflecting that immediacy and accessibility are shaping consumption behaviour, it added.

The report, titled *Inside India's retail reset: The evolution of neighbourhood commerce*, is based on a national survey of over 1,600 consumers and 1,000+ kirana retailers across metros, tier-2 and -3 markets. Respondents included urban and emerging city consumers across income segments, along with neighbourhood grocery store owners operating across traditional retail clusters.

BLENDING CHANNELS

Naaven Malpani, Partner and Consumer Industry Leader, Grant Thornton



IMPULSE & IMMEDIACY. Around 45 per cent of consumers rely on quick commerce for last-minute or urgent purchases, according to a Grant Thornton Bharat report GETTY IMAGES

Bharat, said, "India's retail future will be shaped by how seamlessly traditional and modern channels come together, rather than one replacing the other. The relevance of kiranas will increasingly depend on how effectively they embrace technology, strengthen di-

gital integrations, and tap into premiumisation trends to meet evolving consumer expectations. The next phase of retail will be driven by connected, purpose-led ecosystems where physical and digital retail work in tandem to deliver greater value, convenience, and choice."

IntrCity eyes ₹1,000 crore revenue, 1,000-bus fleet

T E Raja Simhan Chennai

IntrCity, an asset-light technology-driven inter-city bus platform, is targeting ₹1,000 crore in revenue over the next 2-3 years, driven by fleet expansion and rising demand for long-distance road travel in India.

The company, through its partners, operates close to 700 buses and plans to scale up to around 1,000 buses over the next 18-24 months.

The expansion is expected to boost passenger volumes and improve revenue realisation across high-demand routes, said Manish Rathi,



Manish Rathi, CEO, IntrCity TE RAJA SIMHAN

CEO, IntrCity (SmartBus, RailYatri). IntrCity partners with private bus operators rather than owning vehicles. It operates on a revenue-sharing arrangement, where both parties cover their costs

before splitting earnings. This model enables capital-efficient growth while aligning incentives between the platform and its partners.

The firm follows a 50:50 revenue-sharing model with operator partners after covering respective costs. This structure ensures steady revenue streams while incentivising both parties to maximise occupancy and efficiency.

ALTERNATIVE TO TRAIN

Rathi said the company benchmarks its pricing against air-conditioned train fares, typically charging ₹2-2.5 per km. A 500-km journey is priced at around ₹1,000, positioning its services as a

comfortable yet competitive alternative to AC rail travel.

With an average capacity of 35-40 passengers per bus, the current fleet can transport over 20,000 passengers daily. Strong occupancy levels, particularly in South India, which accounts for nearly 60 per cent of operations, are supporting steady revenue growth.

IntrCity has invested ₹200-300 crore over the past decade, largely in technology and customer experience. Its offerings include over 30 boarding lounges, cloud-connected buses with real-time monitoring, and a centralised command centre to track operations.

IRDAI panel to review health cover

G Naga Sridhar Hyderabad

As part of ongoing initiatives to improve policyholder experience and penetration of health insurance, the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI) has constituted a sub-committee of the Insurance Advisory Committee to review the current landscape of private health insurance in India.

The scope of the review includes coverage, penetration, claims experience, product design, grievance redressal and consumer experience.

It will recommend regulatory, policy, and operational measures to promote innovation, wider coverage, better risk pooling, and improved financial protection through health insurance.

"The emphasis will be on increasing trust and the



Scope of the review includes coverage, penetration, claims experience, product design, grievance redressal and consumer experience

overall consumer experience. The sub-committee will also examine the role of healthcare provider networks, hospital tariffs, fraud control, and digital systems in improving value to policyholders, reducing administrative inefficiencies," the insurance regulator said in a release on Tuesday.

A review of interaction between private health in-

surance and public health insurance/assurance schemes, including opportunities for complementarity, portability, and convergence where appropriate will also be done.

GROUPS SET UP BY CII

Further, the sub-committee will examine and incorporate the recommendations emerging from the working groups set up by the Confederation of Indian Industry (CII).

This will cover key issues relating to the health insurance ecosystem including a joint code of conduct for insurers and providers, methodology for commercial engagements and provider classification, adoption and scale-up of the National Health Claims Exchange (NHCE), analytical studies on claim trends and medical inflation, and a framework for a basic product, the release said.

'Rising costs keep truck rentals firm in March'

Our Bureau Chennai

India's mobility and logistics activity remained stable in March, with truck rentals across key trunk routes holding firm and witnessing marginal month-on-month (m-o-m) increases, Shriram Mobility Bulletin, said.

However, LPG tanker movement was significantly impacted during the month due to curtailed supplies.

This firmness was supported by year-end dispatches and rising operating cost pressures, even as overall freight movement remained steady.

Trucking activity showed resilience across most routes year-on-year (y-o-y). The Delhi-Kolkata-Delhi corridor recorded a 10 per cent increase, followed by the Bengaluru-Mumbai-

Bengaluru route (9 per cent). Limited increases were observed across several corridors, indicating stable demand conditions.

The firmness can be attributed to continued industrial and consumption-led movement at the close of the financial year, coupled with fleet availability and the absence of major supply-side disruptions.

BACKLOG EXPECTED

The conflict in West Asia is likely to exert further pressure on logistics operations through rising costs.

Tyre manufacturers have announced price hikes from April 1. This, along with the seasonal increase in toll charges from April 1, is expected to push truck rentals higher. An early onset of summer could lead to some moderation in activity, read the bulletin.

CRED sharpens wealth management push with Kuvera upgrade

Our Bureau Bengaluru

Fintech major CRED is stepping up its push into wealth management, enhancing capabilities on its acquired platform Kuvera and introducing a new invite-only investment product aimed at affluent users.

As part of the revamp, CRED has added deeper analytics, behavioural insights and portfolio recommendations. The platform aims to help users improve decision-making across discipline, asset allocation and performance, areas the company believes are critical for long-term wealth creation.

The rollout will initially target Kuvera's roughly 2 lakh monthly active users. Overall, the platform has about 3 lakh investors and



The rollout will initially target Kuvera's roughly 2 lakh monthly active users GETTY IMAGES

manages nearly ₹33,000 crore in assets.

The company is also nudging investors towards liquid funds through 'Surplus', a feature that deploys idle cash into curated schemes with relatively quick redemption cycles. The product requires a minimum investment of ₹1 lakh and allows withdrawals of up

to ₹4 lakh within five minutes, with the balance redeemable within 24 hours.

CRED has tied up with asset managers like DSP Asset Managers Pvt Ltd, ICICI Prudential Asset Management Company Ltd, Aditya Birla Sun Life AMC Ltd and HDFC Asset Management Company Ltd to offer a curated basket of liquid funds.

ENGAGEMENT PUSH

The upgrade comes as CRED looks to deepen engagement across its 15 million-strong user base, particularly among high-credit-worthy individuals.

Kuvera, which CRED acquired in early 2024 in a cash-and-stock deal, continues to operate as a standalone app. Traditionally focused on mutual fund investing, equity participation surged during Covid-19.

QUICKLY.

Wegovy prices slashed to undercut Lilly's Zepbound



Novo Nordisk will price its new high-dose Wegovy shot at \$399 a month for cash-pay patients, undercutting the cost of most doses of rival Eli Lilly & Co's Zepbound. High-dose Wegovy will be available starting on Tuesday, Novo said. The price is about 40 per cent less than what Lilly charges patients for the top three doses of Zepbound. BLOOMBERG

Gilead agrees to buy cancer biotech Tubulis

Gilead Sciences agreed to buy private German biotech Tubulis GmbH in a deal worth up to \$5 billion as it looks to boost its portfolio in cancer drug development, according to a source. Gilead already sells an ADC drug used for breast cancer, called Trodelvy. Tubulis is testing potential medicines in patient trials for ovarian and lung cancer, as well as other types of tumours. BLOOMBERG

Middle East war opens up new avenues, says Russia

Moscow: Global supply disruptions caused by the war in the Middle East have opened up new trade opportunities for Russia, Prime Minister Mikhail Mishustin told a government meeting on Tuesday. “For our country, the current situation creates new opportunities to improve the financial position of export-oriented industries and to provide additional budget revenues,” he said. Russia is the world's second largest oil exporter, the largest wheat exporter, and a major exporter of fertilizers. REUTERS

‘A whole civilisation will die tonight,’ warns Trump as Iran defies deadline

TICKING CLOCK. Strikes on Iran intensify as US forces hit its main oil export terminal at Kharg Island

Reuters

Dubai/Washington

US President Donald Trump threatened that “a whole civilization will die tonight” as Iran showed no sign of accepting his ultimatum to open the Strait of Hormuz by Tuesday evening, Washington time.

Trump has given Iran until 8 pm in Washington — 3:30 am in Tehran — to end its blockade of Gulf oil or see the US destroy every bridge and power plant in Iran. Iran says it would retaliate against US allies in the Gulf, whose desert cities would be uninhabitable without power or water.

As the clock ticked down on Trump's deadline, strikes on Iran intensified throughout the day, hitting bridges, an airport and a petrochemical plant. US forces attacked



RAID READY. A US Air Force B-52 Stratofortress bomber departs from the RAF Fairford airbase in Fairford, Gloucestershire, Britain, on Tuesday. REUTERS

targets on Kharg Island, home to Iran's main oil export terminal.

Iran responded by declaring it would no longer hold back from hitting its Gulf neighbours' infrastructure, and claimed to have carried

out fresh strikes on a ship in the Gulf and a huge Saudi petrochemical complex.

STRAIT SITUATION

“A whole civilization will die tonight, never to be brought back again. I don't want that

to happen, but it probably will,” Trump wrote on his Truth Social website.

“However, now that we have Complete and Total Regime Change, where different, smarter, and less radicalized minds prevail, may be something revolutionarily wonderful can happen, WHO KNOWS? We will find out tonight, one of the most important moments in the long and complex history of the World.”

Brian Finucane, a former US State Department legal advisor now with the International Crisis Group, said Trump's remarks could “plausibly be interpreted as a threat to commit genocide” under US and international law.

With only hours left before the deadline, a senior Iranian source said Tehran was maintaining its refusal to reopen the strait without US

concessions that so far were not forthcoming.

NO CHANGE

Pakistan, which has been the main go-between, was still relaying messages, but Washington had not changed its tone, the source said.

If the US carried out Trump's threat to hit Iran's power grid, Tehran would plunge Gulf states including Saudi Arabia into darkness, the source added, a threat that had been conveyed to Washington via Qatar.

Earlier, another senior Iranian source told Reuters that Tehran had rejected a proposal conveyed by intermediaries for a temporary ceasefire.

Global markets were largely paralysed, hesitant to bet on whether Trump would follow through on his threats or call them off as he has in the past.

Current gas crisis worse than 1973, 1979, 2002 together, says IEA chief

Reuters
Paris



Fatih Birol, head of the International Energy Agency

The current oil and gas crisis triggered by the blockade of the Strait of Hormuz is “more serious than the ones in 1973, 1979 and 2002 together”, Fatih Birol, the head of the International Energy Agency (IEA), told *Le Figaro* newspaper.

“The world has never experienced a disruption to energy supply of such magnitude,” he said in an interview with the French newspaper released in its Tuesday edition.

CATALYSED INFLATION

He said the European countries, as well as Japan, Australia and others will suffer, but the countries most at risk were developing nations, which will suffer from higher oil and gas prices, higher food prices and a general acceleration of inflation.

The IEA member countries agreed last month to release part of their strategic reserves. Some of this had already been released and the process continues, said Birol.

In reaction to the strikes by Israel and the US, Iran has almost entirely blocked traffic in the Strait of Hormuz, through which about 20 per cent of world oil and gas regularly flows, creating a surge in energy prices.

Bangladesh set to discuss trade, energy, transit issues with India

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

Bangladesh's Foreign Minister Khalilur Rahman is in India for a key round of meetings with the country's top leadership on issues such as trade, energy and transit, marking the first high-level engagement since the new government took office in Dhaka.

The visit is being seen as an early “testing of the waters” amid tensions in bilateral ties following the ouster of former Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina, who sought refuge in India.

Discussions are expected to focus on securing energy supplies, resolving trans-

shipment rights, navigating Bangladesh's 2026 LDC graduation, and a possible renegotiation of the power purchase agreement with Adani Power, sources said.

THORNY ISSUES

“While Dhaka has projected the trip as a short stopover en route to Mauritius, the talks are likely to outline core positions and set strategic priorities for the next phase of bilateral relations,” a source tracking the matter told *businessline*.

Thorny issues, including transshipment rights and Bangladesh's upcoming graduation from Least Developed Country (LDC) status, a transition that threatens the duty-free



FRESH APPROACH. Bangladesh Foreign Minister Khalilur Rahman's visit is being seen as “testing of the waters” amid tensions following the ouster of former PM Sheikh Hasina. ANI

status currently enjoyed by Dhaka, are likely to come up in Rahman's meetings with Commerce & Industry Minister Piyush Goyal and External Affairs Minister S

Jaishankar on Wednesday.

Last year, New Delhi revoked the transshipment facility that allowed Bangladesh to export goods to third countries via Indian

Transshipment rights and LDC status of Bangladesh are likely to come up in the meetings

land customs stations, ports, and airports.

While India said this was done to sort out port congestion issues, this was also viewed as a reaction to Dhaka's interim government deciding to shut down three land ports with India and suspending operations at another land port.

Dhaka's move specifically targeted India's rice exports. India's curbs also affected

exports of Bangladesh's jute and fibre. “Since this is the first time that the Ministers would be sitting together to discuss issues, the transshipment issues in India and closure of ports in Bangladesh are to be among the priority items that would be taken up,” the source said.

FTA TALKS

As Bangladesh would want to retain its duty free access to the Indian market even after it graduates out of its LDC status in 2026, the Minister is likely to take the matter up with his Indian counterparts.

India and Bangladesh had been discussing the possibility of a free trade agreement (FTA) with former Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina's

government but after her ouster the talks stalled.

Energy security will also dominate the discussions, with Bangladesh seeking electricity cooperation and fuel supplies, amid the West Asia crisis, to stabilise its economy.

Bangladesh is seeking to renegotiate its long-term power purchase agreement with Adani Power due to concerns over high import costs and alleged anomalies in pricing.

“The Bangladesh Minister's discussions with Petroleum Minister Hardeep Puri will be important as energy supplies to Dhaka, amid the ongoing crisis in West Asia, will be taken up,” the source said.

War raises fear of worker exodus from West Asia; remittance flows at risk, too

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

India's concerns about the conflict in West Asia are mounting not just over a near-term dip in remittances but also over the larger risk of Indian workers returning home if the hostilities drag on.

A top source said that while financial flows remain stable for now, the situation could turn more complex if the war continues to disrupt industrial operations in the Gulf economies that employ millions of Indians.

“Various refineries and other establishments having a large number of Indian workers are not functional at this moment. While senior functionaries continue to be stationed, lower-level workers have moved from there. Since as of now they are holding money and not sending it to India, remittances



Indians in Gulf countries

Country	No. of Workers
United Arab Emirates	43,26,248
Saudi Arabia	27,47,551
Kuwait	10,36,389
Qatar	8,30,491
Oman	6,76,781
Bahrain	3,17,564

Source - Ministry of External Affairs

could be impacted too. Also, if the war continues, they are likely to come back,” a highly placed source said.

The anxiety stems from the sheer scale of Indian workforce presence in the Gulf Cooperation Council

(GCC) region. Government data show that more than 9.9 million Indians currently reside across six GCC countries.

Officials say that any largescale return migration could strain the domestic labour markets while also hitting household incomes dependent on overseas earnings.

UNDER PRESSURE

For now, authorities are not flagging immediate macroeconomic stress. Sources maintained that credit availability to industry remains comfortable and inflationary pressures are not expected in the near-term despite the geopolitical turbulence.

Remittance flows, a crucial pillar of India's external finances, have remained robust so far.

According to a Finance Ministry report, remittance inflows during the third quarter (October-December)

of FY26 rose to \$36.9 billion, up from \$35.1 billion in the corresponding period of FY25.

However, officials acknowledged that the Gulf region's dominant role in India's remittance ecosystem makes the situation particularly sensitive.

GCC economies accounted for 38 per cent of India's total remittances in 2023-24 and host nearly half of Indian migrants worldwide.

The Finance Ministry report noted that sustained geopolitical instability could indirectly weaken remittance flows by putting pressure on Gulf fiscal balances, especially if oil prices remain volatile or industrial operations remain disrupted.

At present, the immediate concern appears to be behavioural rather than structural, workers conserving cash rather than remitting it, amid uncertainty over employment continuity.

Sri Lanka announces \$317 million ‘relief package’ to cope with West Asia crisis

Meera Srinivasan
Colombo

Sri Lanka on Tuesday rolled out relief measures to help citizens cope with the impact of the war in West Asia.

Addressing Parliament, President Anura Kumara Disanayake announced fuel and fertilizer subsidies, and a temporary increase in the government's targeted cash transfer programme for the poor.

Further, the government will bear the cost of electricity for consumers using less than 90 units over the next three months.

“The total relief package is valued at 100 billion rupees [roughly \$317 million] over three months,” he said, adding that the “relief package” was being funded this

through the existing Budget.

Disanayake's announcement comes a week before Sri Lankans mark the Sinhala and Tamil New Year, one of the biggest festivals celebrated on the island. It also coincides with the government's ongoing talks with a visiting delegation of the International Monetary Fund (IMF).

SECOND MAJOR CRISIS

A staff-level agreement for the next tranche of the Fund's \$2.9 billion assistance to Sri Lanka, extended following the 2022 economic crash, is expected this week.

Meanwhile, ordinary citizens, already grappling with IMF-linked austerity, are now forced to contend with sharp hikes in fuel, LPG and electricity prices owing to the West Asia conflict, the

second major crisis to impact Sri Lanka after Cyclone Ditwah in December 2025.

Amid the persisting uncertainty in fuel supplies and global oil prices, Sri Lanka is in talks with Russia and China to augment supplies in the coming months.

INDIAN ASSISTANCE

On March 28, India delivered 38,000 tonnes of petroleum to Sri Lanka, including 20,000 tonnes of diesel and 18,000 tonnes of petrol, following a telephone call between President Disanayake and Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

SMOOTH SUPPLY

A top official at the state-run Ceylon Petroleum Corporation (CPC), which has over 70 per cent of the market share, said the country's cur-

rent fuel stocks will ensure smooth supply until the end of May.

“We have been talking to Russia, and we are now in discussion with China, to augment supply going forward,” Mayura Netthikumarage, Managing Director of CPC, told *The Hindu*.

“The QR-code system introduced last month to manage supplies has helped us,” he added, referring to the government's decision to ration fuel sales, limiting weekly quotas, depending on the category of the vehicle.

Sources at Lanka IOC, a subsidiary of the Indian Oil Corporation in Sri Lanka, the second largest supplier on the island, said that it had stocks to last until mid-May.

Meera Srinivasan is *The Hindu* correspondent in Colombo

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QUICKLY.

Gold steady as Trump's Iran deadline looms



Gold prices were little changed on Tuesday as caution prevailed in the market ahead of the expiry of an US ultimatum warning Iran to reopen the Strait of Hormuz. Spot gold was up 0.2 per cent at \$4,659.35 per ounce by 1325 GMT. US gold futures steadied at \$4,684.50. REUTERS

Oil palm tops ₹23,000 in Telangana

Hyderabad: Oil palm price in Telangana has gone up by ₹1,459 per tonne of fresh fruit bunch (FFB), taking the total price to ₹23,005 a tonne. “Increased prices would attract more farmers to grow the plantation crop. It will increase confidence among the farmers,” Telangana Agriculture, Marketing and Cooperation Tummala Nageswara Rao said. OUR BUREAU

Aluminium gains on UAE smelter repairs



London: Aluminium prices rose with the key LME spread jumping as markets priced in prolonged repairs at a UAE smelter hit by an Iranian attack last month. The three-month aluminium contract on the LME gained 0.9 per cent to \$3,501 a tonne by 0940 GMT. Copper rose 0.6 per cent to \$12,430. REUTERS

‘S-W Monsoon will be below-normal this year’

PREDICTING TROUBLE. Private weather forecaster Skymet says the monsoon will be 94 per cent of the long-period average

Srikrishnan PC
Chennai

Private weather forecast agency Skymet has predicted a below-normal monsoon this year in view of El Nino emerging later this year. Skymet, which has come out with its prediction of the South-West Monsoon at least 10 days ahead of the India Meteorological Department, expects the monsoon to be 94 per cent (with an error margin of +/- 5 per cent) of the long-period average (LPA) of 868.6 mm for the 4-month-long period from June to September. The South-West Monsoon makes up about three-fourths of the annual rainfall in the country. It is key for kharif crop production, making up over 50 per cent of the total agri-

cultural output annually. **POSITIVE IOD IMPACT** Jatin Singh, Managing Director, Skymet, said: “After a year and a half of La Nina conditions, the Pacific Ocean has turned favourable for ENSO-neutral. Equatorial Pacific Ocean-atmosphere coupling is now stronger than before. El Nino is expected during the early phase of the South-West Monsoon and will keep growing stronger till fall of the year. El Nino return may presage a weaker monsoon. The second half of the season is likely to be more erratic and irregular.” Skymet said besides ENSO, the Indian Ocean Dipole had the capacity to drive monsoon circulation. A strong positive IOD event during the season had the potential to partially



WEAK RAINS. The core monsoon rain-fed zone of the central and western parts may witness inadequate rainfall. Punjab, Haryana and Rajasthan are likely to see less than normal rain

avert the ill effects of El Nino. The IOD is expected to be neutral or delicately positive. It will approvingly contribute to a decent start of the monsoon. However, the chances of the monsoon getting impaired during the second half of the season cannot be dismissed. The seasonal rainfall distribution will be at risk of being diverse and biased.

businessline had mentioned these possibilities in reports in February and earlier this month. **EAST, NORTH-EAST BETTER PLACED** Skymet expects the core monsoon rain-fed zone of the central and western parts to witness inadequate rainfall. Punjab, Haryana and Rajasthan are likely to observe less than normal rain, and more so, during August-September. The Eastern and North-Eastern parts will be placed better than the rest of the country. Providing details of the possibilities, the weather agency said chances of excess rainfall were nil (110 per cent and above of LPA), while there was a 10 per cent chance of the rainfall being

105-100 per cent of the LPA. Chances of normal rainfall were 20 per cent, while there was a 40 per cent chance of below-normal rainfall and a 30 per cent chance of drought. **CLIMATE SWING** Drought-bearing El Nino is a largescale warming of sea surface temperatures in the central and eastern equatorial Pacific, accompanied by shifts in tropical atmospheric circulation, including changes in wind patterns, air pressure and rainfall distribution. In 2023, the event began in June and persisted for 11 months. Though the monsoon was 94 per cent of LPA, it left at least a third of the country dry. Foodgrain output was affected due to this, driving up food inflation.

Before 2023, El Nino emerged between 2018 and 2019. This weak event followed a very strong El Nino during 2014-16. **ECONOMIC SIGNIFICANCE** The South-West monsoon is key to the country's economic growth as a good kharif harvest leads to a thriving rural economy. Higher purchases by rural India leads to demand for fast moving consumer goods, tractors, automobiles, jewellery, electronics and white goods. Any failure in the monsoon could undermine economic growth. This year, the below-normal forecast comes at a time when the agriculture sector is facing rising costs of fertilizers, crop inputs and fuel due to the Iran war.

Sugar offtake in April may fall by 2 lt on cool weather, LPG scarcity

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

The sugar industry has said that consumption of sugar, which was higher by 60,000 tonnes until February in the current season from the allocation, dropped by 2 lakh tonnes in March and will likely to see the same level of fall this month. This is due to lower temperatures and the crisis because of the short supply of LPG cylinders. The Food Ministry, which regulates the sugar sector, allocated 110.5 lakh tonnes (lt) in the first five months (October-February) of 2025-26 season to mills for domestic sales, which was 3.5 per cent lower from 114.5 lt from the year-ago period.

The Ministry had released 22.5 lt in March and 23 lt for April, which is 0.5 lt, each less from the year-ago period. Speaking to the media on the sidelines of an event, Deepak Ballani, Director-General of Indian Sugar & Bio-energy Manufacturers Association (ISMA), said that the despatches (sales) by mills during October-February was 60,000 tonnes more than the allocated quota. **GROSS OUTPUT** Ballani said sugar consumption in the whole season may drop to 277 lt in 2025-26 from 281 lt in 2024-25. Food Ministry data show that the allocation of domestic sales quota was 275.5 lt in the entire 2025-26 sea-

son. He also said that gross sugar production is likely to be 320 lt this season, which is marginally lower than ISMA's previous estimate of 324 lt. The net output may be 285-286 lt after considering 34-35 lt of diversion towards ethanol. Food Secretary Sanjeev Chopra said that the government is expecting gross sugar production in the current season to be between 320 lt and 325 lt, which is lower from its initial estimate of 330 lt. He said diversion towards ethanol could be 35 lt, leaving a net sugar output of 285-290 lt. On plans to ban sugar exports, he said: “As of now, there is no such proposal.” He said the government had approved over 15 lt of sugar for export, but initially there

was an export parity issue. But after the fighting started in West Asia, prices had firmed up a bit, which boosted exports. “Still, I think it will be very challenging for us to see the entire quantity which we've approved getting exported,” he said. Chopra clarified that the quantity that will not get exported will remain in the country and add to the closing balance. “Next year, when we consider the diversion for ethanol, if our closing balance is that large, we will have more flexibility, and we can probably do more of the ethanol blending,” he said. **FLEXI-FUEL POLICY** “India, having achieved E20, appears increasingly likely to

pursue a further expansion of its ethanol mandate. While India has capacity for further ethanol expansion, realising it will require the country to further restrict sugar exports, weighing on global supply and underpinning prices at the margin,” BMI, a unit of Fitch Solutions, said in a report, ‘Outlook for sugar prices’ published in *businessline* on April 6. Asked specifically on any plan to raise ethanol blending beyond 20 per cent, the Food Secretary said current capacity is almost 2,000 crore litres per annum, which is surplus compared to the demand. “What should be done with it (surplus) — whether increase the ethanol blending percentage or look at

other avenues — there are many suggestions like promoting flex-fuel vehicles. A committee has been formed to consider this, and I think before the next ethanol season begins (from November 2026), the government will probably have some news on that as well,” Chopra said. **ETHANOL STOVE** On the demand for allowing ethanol in stoves, he said it needs some regulatory changes to be done by the Petroleum Ministry and the Bureau of Indian Standards (BIS). “That is right now under consideration, and I am hopeful that some enabling provisions can be made so that at least in the vicinity of ethanol distilleries, we can popularise the ethanol

stove,” he said. The industry's demand to raise the minimum selling price of sugar is still under consideration, he added. **WHEAT CROP** On the wheat crop outlook, Chopra said it is looking good. But there were requests from Haryana and Rajasthan for relaxation of the fair average quality (FAQ) norms after unseasonal rain hit the crop. “We have sent our teams to these States to find out the ground-level position and, if required, we'll give them the relaxation very soon so that the farmers do not suffer any problem in selling the produce,” he said. The Food Secretary also ruled out any plan to lower import duty on edible oils.

Egg exports develop crack on spike in freight costs

Vishwanath Kulkarni
Bengaluru

Egg exporters are battling shipping disruptions and a near five-fold surge in freight costs due to the West Asia war, even as export demand stays strong and domestic demand weakens. The fallout has stranded shipments, flooded the local market and pushed prices below cost. Of 125 delayed containers, 90-95 have now reached destinations, offering partial relief. But 5-10 remain stuck at JNPT and about 30 are still on a vessel near Dammam, likely to clear in a few days, said Valsan Parameswaran, Secretary, All India Poultry Exporters Association. With eggs' 90-day shelf life already half spent for many consignments, time is of the essence. The bigger hit, how-

Exporters seek more sailing frequency, subsidies to offset hike in freight costs

ever, is freight; container rates have jumped from nearly \$1,800 to \$9,500-\$10,500, eroding margins. Limited support from the Export Credit Guarantee Corporation of India (ECGC) has helped, but exporters want more support, especially from Kochi, and freight subsidies. **DESPITE DEMAND** Pre-war, India shipped 80 lakh-1 crore eggs daily (about 20 containers), largely from Namakkal. Now, barely 1-2 containers move every few days, he said. This, despite strong demand in the UAE, Oman, Qatar and West

Africa, amid supply gaps from Iran and Türkiye. Despite this, Indian exporters are struggling to service the orders due to shipping constraints and limited vessel availability. **PRICES SLIDE** The export slump has swamped the domestic market, dragging prices down from about ₹540 per 100 eggs to nearly ₹430, well below the below the production cost of ₹450 — translating into daily losses of around ₹5 crore for South Indian farmers. Besides, seasonal factors have compounded the pressure. “Demand has softened following Ramadan and Easter, while school closures have cut mid-day meal off-take. Lower summer consumption has further weakened the market,” Parameswaran said.

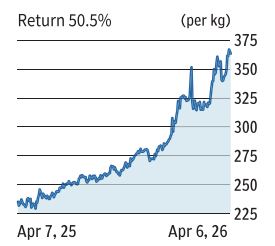
Stay long on aluminium futures; raise stop-loss to ₹340

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau

Aluminium futures are now trading at ₹354 per kg. While the price movement has largely been flat over the last week, there was a sharp drop in price on April 1, but it recovered the same day.

COMMODITY CALL.

The April futures slipped to a low of ₹329.60 on April 1. However, it recovered the same day, closing the session at ₹355.65. Barring this temporary blip, over the past week, the contract has largely been oscillating between ₹350 and ₹358. That said, the broader price action shows that aluminium futures retain a bullish bias. We expect the contract to break out of the hurdle at ₹358 and rally to ₹380. If the price dips, alu-



minium futures could find support at ₹350 and ₹340. Subsequent support is at ₹330. Only a breach of ₹330 will turn the outlook bearish. Overall, the outlook is positive. An eventual breakout of ₹358 could lead to a rally to ₹380. **TRADE STRATEGY** We had suggested buying aluminium futures if there was a decline to ₹340. Traders who executed this trade can retain it. But revise the stop-loss from ₹325 to ₹340. When the contract surpasses ₹360, revise the stop-loss to ₹348. Exit at ₹380.

Industry body urges Maharashtra to retain inspector-free fertilizer policy

Our Bureau
Pune

The Indian Micro Fertilizers Manufacturers Association (IMMA), representing a majority of India's micronutrient manufacturers, has urged the Maharashtra government to retain its inspector-free regulatory framework for the fertilizer sector, warning that any rollback could adversely impact the ease of doing business and investor confidence. In a letter, dated April 4, addressed to Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis, the association highlighted that Maharashtra had become the first State in the country to implement an inspector-free regime through a government order issued in June 2025. The move, IMMA noted, had been widely appreciated for promoting trust-based governance, en-

couraging grassroots manufacturing, and strengthening industry confidence. The association, which claims to represent nearly 80 per cent of India's micronutrient manufacturing sector, emphasised its long-standing collaboration with the government authorities in enhancing agricultural productivity and farmer incomes. It pointed to its involvement in policy-making bodies, including committees under the Bureau of Indian Standards, as evidence of its institutional role in shaping the sector. **REGULATORY SYSTEM** However, IMMA expressed concern over a reported proposal to reintroduce an inspector-driven regulatory system, involving increased deployment of inspectors with broad enforcement powers. According to the letter, discussions on this pro-

posal were held in October 2025 and January 2026 without adequate participation from key industry stakeholders. IMMA argued that reinstating a more restrictive regulatory framework could undermine Maharashtra's position as a leader in progressive agri-sector reforms. It warned that the spirit of trust-based governance, which had enabled better collaboration between industry and the government, may be weakened if the proposal is implemented. Calling for a reconsideration, the association urged the Chief Minister's office to withdraw any move towards reinstating the inspector-based regime. It maintained that continuing the current framework would help sustain investment, boost innovation, and strengthen agricultural productivity in the State.

How Chittoor farmers are ‘harvesting’ the land and the sun

Our Bureau
Hyderabad

Project Chittoor, launched by the Atria Group to demonstrate a well-rounded model for rural development, has deployed an agrivoltaic solar project at Thirumala Raju Puram (Palam) in Chittoor district. The project introduces field integrated agrivoltaic systems, where solar panels are installed above active farmland, allowing crops and clean energy generation to co-exist on the same land. The elevated solar panels provide partial shading, which helps reduce heat stress and evaporation for certain crops, improving farm resilience during hotter months.



SUNSCREEN. The elevated panels provide partial shading, which helps reduce heat stress and evaporation for certain crops such as tomatoes, brinjal, and okra. Power generated from the agrivoltaic installations will be used to operate shared agricultural infrastructure within the farming clusters, including pumps, borewells, cold storage units, dryers, packhouses and other processing facilities. **ADDITIONAL INCOME** “This would reduce operating costs and lower depend-

Pune-based BiofuelCircle sets up over 70 biomass banks

Subramani Ra Mancombu
Chennai

Pune-based BiofuelCircle, a five-year-old start-up that has launched a unique farm-to-fuel ecosystem connecting farmers, has set up 70 biomass banks over the past three years, Co-founder and CEO Suhas Baxi said. “Typically, these units involve an investment of about ₹3 crore and generate annual revenues in the range of ₹3-₹4 crore. The biomass banks have created a growing network of rural enterprises linked to the biomass supply chain,” Baxi told *businessline*. The company views each biomass bank in its network as an independent rural micro-enterprise designed to operate on commercially viable principles. **10 UNITS PROFITABLE** “The first 10 units in our net-

work are already profitable, while the next 25 units are steadily progressing toward the same stage of profitability. Based on current performance trends, a typical unit becomes EBITDA positive within 12-18 months and can achieve a capital payback period of roughly 3-4 years,” said Baxi. No unit of the company has yet completed a full four-year cycle. Though long-term proof will emerge over time, early indicators strongly suggest that profitable and sustainable rural enterprises can be built around biomass aggregation and supply chains, said the firm's Co-founder and CEO. “Beyond financial viability, these enterprises also create local employment and establish structured markets for agricultural residues,” he said, adding that the farm-to-fuel-to-soil model has the potential to become eco-



BiofuelCircle's biomass bank in Nagpur, Maharashtra

nomically self-sustaining when implemented at scale. **ROLE OF SUBSIDIES** Subsidies should serve as an investment accelerator rather than a financial crutch. “Like most infrastructure-driven sectors, bioenergy businesses typically require a three-to-five-year payback horizon, and policy incentives can help attract early capital and prioritise invest-

ment in the sector,” said Baxi. However, the long-term sustainability of the business cannot depend on subsidies. If a model requires ongoing subsidies for operational viability, it indicates a structural weakness, he said. Biofuel's focus is on building supply chains and operational processes first, which establishes a reliable biomass aggregation and logistics system. This will ensure feedstock is available at “predictable” prices. Baxi said bioenergy alone will not eliminate fossil fuel dependence, but it could reduce reliance on fossil imports and diversify the energy mix. “When integrated with other renewable sources such as solar and wind, decentralised bioenergy contributes to stronger energy resilience and supply diversification,” he said. BiofuelCircle is trying to build a reliable supply chain through its digital biomass marketplace, which connects producers, aggregators and industrial buyers through common systems and processes. On not relying on carbon credits and sustainability incentives, he said such incentives should act as an added benefit that rewards environmental impact. They cannot be the determining factor in financial viability, he said.

QUICKLY.

No cash at toll plazas from April 10: Highways Ministry

New Delhi: Cash payments at toll plazas will be discontinued on National Highways from April 10, the Road Transport and Highways Ministry has said. In a gazette notification, it said that in cases where a vehicle enters a fee plaza without a valid FASTag, users can still pay via UPI, but at a higher charge of 1.25 times the applicable toll fee. A senior NHAI official said that the move is aimed at reducing long queues at toll gates and making highway travel smoother. **PM**

AstraZeneca, Telangana ink pact for AI lung screening

Hyderabad: AstraZeneca Pharma India signed an MoU with the Telangana government to introduce AI-enabled lung cancer screening across public healthcare facilities in the State. AstraZeneca will facilitate the deployment of Qure.ai's AI-powered chest X-ray solution, to be integrated into routine workflows at public health facilities. **OUR BUREAU**

I-T reform brings relief to armed forces, personnel to take home more

LESS TAXING. New I-T Rules 2026 fix decades-old anomalies by removing outdated exemption limits

Dalip Singh
New Delhi

The Income Tax Rules, 2026, effective from April 1, have addressed long-standing anomalies in the old tax regime by removing exemption limits that remained unchanged for over three decades. These changes bring significant relief to armed forces personnel receiving hardship allowances for postings in extreme conditions, including high-altitude regions such as the Siachen Glacier, the world's highest battlefield. According to CBDT officials, the earlier limits were stuck at 1995 levels, resulting in a situation where soldiers had to pay tax on a substantial portion of their hardship allowances, leaving them with minimal take-home benefits.

For instance, personnel posted in Siachen receive a hardship allowance of ₹42,500 per month, but only ₹7,000 was exempt from tax under the previous rules. This meant that ₹35,500, which was over 83 per cent of the allowance, was taxable, CBDT sources said. Over time, while the risks and costs associated with such postings increased, the tax-exempt portion of these allowances failed to keep pace with inflation and evolving operational demands.

ALLOWANCES COVERED Recognising this gap, the Finance Ministry revised the provisions under the Income Tax Act, 1961, acknowledging that outdated caps were effectively “penalising” personnel serving in difficult conditions, they explained. The updated rules are ex-



TOUGH TIMES. Earlier limits, unchanged since 1995, taxed much of hardship allowances, leaving soldiers minimal take-home benefits

pected to benefit over one crore employees and their families. Previously governed by Rule 2BB under the Finance Act, 1995, the framework covered various allowances for the armed forces and government employees working in challenging environments, including border areas, counter-insurgency zones and high-altitude loca-

tions. It also included provision for children's education, hostels and disability allowances. However, over the years, many of these allowances were restructured, renamed or merged, and deployment areas were revised. Despite these changes, exemption limits remained static. For example, the children's education allowance

for government employees stands at ₹2,812.5 per month, but the exempt amount was capped at just ₹100 under the old rules, CBDT sources stated. The new Rule 280 under the Income Tax Rules, 2026, consolidates these updates by reflecting current allowance structures, revised hardship categories and updated exemption limits. It also introduces a more streamlined and digitisation-friendly format, replacing the earlier text-heavy provisions that were not easily compatible with payroll software systems. The revised framework enables precise mapping of allowances to specific locations and limits, ensuring accurate tax calculations without ambiguity and aligning them with current pay commission structures, sources pointed out.



DRDO Chief Samir V Kamat **ANI**

DRDO chief urges faster materials development to match rapid tech cycles

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) Chairman Samir V Kamat on Tuesday sought a sharp reduction of the development cycle for critical material from the existing 10 to 15 years to “keep pace” with “continuously shrinking” system development timelines and enhance the country's technological capabilities. “Materials are key enablers, whether for systems, weapons or sensors. If you want capabilities beyond what you currently possess, you must develop materials that can provide that capability,” he said at the CAPS-IMR Joint Seminar hosted at Subroto Park here.

BIG CHALLENGE According to Kamat, the biggest challenge today is that the material development cycle is 10-15 years. If you see, the system development cycle is continuously shrinking. “Today, new systems arrive every five years and in areas like drones, things change every couple of years or every year.” So, unless the material development cycle keeps pace with the system development cycle, “getting any new material is becoming a greater and greater challenge,” the DRDO chief added.

“You are not going to get it. They will give you the technology only after they have used it in their systems. And, when they move to the next generation technologies, they give you the various components of technology needed for making your systems,” Kamat said. “So if you have any ambition of becoming *aatmanirbhar* and a technology leader, this is one area — not the only area, but one area —

that the country needs to focus on,” he asserted. Kamat said the materials community attempted to shorten the materials development cycle, using integrated computational materials engineering and AI/ML tools. “I am very hopeful that in the next five to 10 years, the materials community will also be able to shrink the material cycle.” He also called for investment in extraction technologies for exploiting the presence of rare earth resources available in the country. “See, today we have magnet technology, but we don't have rare earth metals,” he emphasised. China controls 90 per cent of rare earth metals. And for the heavy rare earths needed in neodymium, iron and boron magnets, China has 99 per cent dominance, the DRDO chief added. Air Marshal Umesh Yalla, Air Officer Commanding-in-Chief of the Maintenance Command of the Indian Air Force, said, “The military aerospace manufacturing industry has largely grown around licensed manufacturing of mainly airframe structures built to foreign OEM designs. Engines, aggregates, accessories and avionics are usually supplied as a kit. Whenever these are allowed to be built within India, tight control over critical parts technology, processes and raw materials is ensured by the foreign OEM. In essence, we continue depending on the foreign OEMs.”

Social ill cannot be branded as ‘religious practice’: SC on Sabarimala issue

Krishnadas Rajagopal
New Delhi

BV Nagarathna, the sole woman judge in the Supreme Court and the nine-member Bench hearing a reference spurred by a 2018 judgment upholding the right of women of menstruating age to worship at the Sabarimala shrine, said on Monday that social ills cannot be branded as “essential religious practices”. The Centre, which holds the position that the Sabarimala judgment was an intrusion into the free exercise of religious freedoms and denominational rights, said the legislature, and not the courts, drives social reform and welfare in religion. “If social evils

are given a religious colour, then the courts can intervene to distinguish the two,” Justice Nagarathna said on Tuesday. Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, who opened the arguments before the nine-judge Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, said the Preamble to the Constitution champions liberty of thought, expression, belief, faith and worship. “How can the courts then examine the essentiality of religious practices of a denomination which does not otherwise offend public order, morality and health?” Mehta asked. The exchange marked the first day of hearing of a reference to evolve a “judicial policy” for constitutional



courts while dealing with questions of right to religious freedom enshrined in Article 25 and a denomination's privilege to manage its own religious affairs under Article 26 of the Constitution.

PLENARY REACH The focal point of the reference is how far courts can use plenary powers to judicially review religious practices

considered “essential or core” in the name of ushering in social reform. “The reasons for empowering the legislature to introduce social welfare and reform are obvious. If a religion or religious practice requires any social welfare measure or even reform, it must emanate from within the religion or from within the society and cannot be imposed by a judicial dictum,” Mehta submitted. He said the top court's decision in the current reference would influence the trajectory of the nation for decades to come. “The courts would first have to decide if it is a religious practice by interpreting the religious texts concerned.

These texts require examination by religious scholars to understand what was actually meant at the time it was written. That is impossible for a court to do,” Mehta submitted. The 2018 judgment had upheld the right of women to enter the Sabarimala temple while rejecting arguments that it was an ancient custom essential to the nature of the deity, Lord Ayyappa, in the *Naishtika Brahmachari* form, presiding at the shrine. “Can the attribute of a deity [*Naishtika Brahmachari*] be judicially reviewed?” the top law officer queried. Justice Ahsanuddin Amanullah asked if the Solicitor was trying to point out

that courts must not get into the examination of the essentiality of a religious practice at all. “I am saying that this — the essentiality of a religious practice — may not fall within the domain of judicial review,” Mehta responded. Justice Joymalya Bagchi referred to the fact that courts do entertain civil suits on ecclesiastical matters. “Judges are not experts in science. Yet, courts are empowered by the Evidence Act to examine the opinions of scientific experts and become an expert of experts,” Justice Bagchi observed. Justice MM Sundresh intervened to note that “the difference here is science is based on logic, and religion is based on belief”.

Ladakh stakeholders seek curbs on outside investments

Gulzar Bhat
Srinagar

Tourism stakeholders in Ladakh have raised concerns over outside investment in the region, warning that it could undermine local businesses and employment opportunities. At a meeting on Sunday, the Ladakh Tourist Trade Alliance, an amalgam of several Leh-based trade bodies, adopted a resolution seeking safeguards to protect local livelihoods. The group said the increasing entry of non-local investors into the tourism sector could marginalise small, locally-owned enterprises. “We are not against development, but it should not come at the cost of local stakeholders,” members of the alliance said, urging the authorities to put in place measures to ensure that benefits accrue to residents. The concerns come in the backdrop of constitutional changes in 2019, when the



PUSH FOR RIGHTS. Since losing special status, Ladakh locals have sought Sixth Schedule safeguards for land and jobs

Union government abrogated Article 370 and Article 35A, and reorganised the erstwhile State of Jammu and Kashmir into two Union Territories — Jammu and Kashmir, and Ladakh. With the removal of earlier protections related to land ownership and jobs, stakeholders said the region had become more open to outside investment.

LOCAL CONCERNS Tsetan Angchuk, Chairperson of the Ladakh Travel Trade Alliance, said the short

tourism window makes local businesses particularly vulnerable. “Tourist season in Ladakh is already short. It lasts for not more than four to five months, and whatever business we generate during this period sustains us for the entire year,” he said. “If large outside players dominate the sector, local operators will find it difficult to survive.” “There are rumours that large hotel chains may enter the region,” he added, expressing concern that such developments could further

strain local businesses. In Ladakh's cold desert economy, an estimated 13,000 to 14,000 families depend on tourism for their livelihood. Industry representatives said any shift in ownership patterns could have far-reaching economic implications. The alliance has previously taken steps to counter outside investment. Last year, it blacklisted 11 properties over non-local investment, following which six properties withdrew such arrangements, according to stakeholders. Broader political demands are also linked to the issue. Since the loss of special status, people in Ladakh have been seeking inclusion under the Sixth Schedule of the Constitution, which provides safeguards for land and jobs for locals. Stakeholders said such protections are essential to ensure balanced development and to preserve local interests, amid growing external investment.

‘Office transactions saw record growth in Q1’

Aneesh Phadnis
Mumbai

The office market saw record absorption of 29.9 million sq ft in the first quarter of 2026, but the residential segment is seeing signs of a slowdown, with a 4 per cent decline in sales, real estate consultancy Knight Frank said in its report on Tuesday. Sales momentum in the residential space was subdued, with all the main markets, including Mumbai, the New Delhi Capital Region and Pune, witnessing a decline in sales. Units above ₹1 crore recorded 11 per cent year-on-year growth in sales, but those priced less than ₹50 lakh and between ₹50 lakh and ₹1 crore contracted 23 per cent and 12 per cent, respectively. Unsold inventory levels in the residential segment have continued to rise since 2020, driven by supply consistently outpacing sales. This increase has been largely concentrated in the ₹1 crore and above 10 seg-

ment, reflecting sustained developer focus on higher ticket size projects in recent years. While the residential space is seeing fatigue, the office segment is on an upswing, said Gulam Zia, International Partner and Senior Executive

Director, Knight Frank. According to the report, commercial leasing activity in the country is dominated by global capability centres, and these were the primary growth drivers in Q1. GCCs accounted for 14.4 msf or 48 per cent of total leasing in the

quarter. Among other occupier segments, India-facing businesses and third-party IT services operators accounted for 19 per cent and 15 per cent of total leasing, respectively. Mumbai and Hyderabad saw record commercial leasing activity.

Nearly half the working population has diabetes or is pre-diabetic: Apollo Hospitals report

Our Bureau
Chennai

Over eight of 10 Indian professionals surveyed were found to be overweight and nearly half were pre-diabetic or diabetic, according to Apollo Hospitals' yearly Health of Nation (HoN) Survey. The study drew on nearly 3 million preventive health assessments across Apollo's pan-India network, which included 5,00,000 corporate health assessments and 1,00,000 assessments of people under the age of 30. It emphasised the need for individuals to look beyond disease prevention and proactively optimise their health. The report noted that one in four surveyed employees had high blood pressure, and over two-thirds were not



meeting basic activity levels like 150 minutes of moderate exercise per week. Among people under the age of 30, more than half were overweight and had abnormal cholesterol, while 70 per cent were deficient in Vitamin D. Nearly two-thirds of under-30s assessed had poor flexibility, strength or balance. **WOMEN'S HEALTH** As for women's health, the report flagged shifting health risks across life stages with high anaemia in younger wo-

men, peak B12 deficiency in women in their 20s, rising central obesity by their 40s and a 2.5x increase in diabetes risk post-menopause. The report also showed sharp geographic variation in disease burden. Interestingly, tier-2 cities like Madurai, Mysuru and Tiruchirappalli show higher disease prevalence than tier-1 metros like Mumbai and Bengaluru. “For too long, health checks were viewed as routine blood tests and vitals, merely a reactive response driven by fear. Today, genuine health is personal, proactive and highly precise. Since no two lives are the same, our approach to prevention must be as individual as the people we serve,” Prathap C Reddy, Founder-Chairman, Apollo Hospitals, said in a statement.

AP clears ₹39,436 cr worth projects, to create 1.11 lakh jobs

Our Bureau
Hyderabad

The Andhra Pradesh State Investment Promotion Board (SIPB) has approved 31 proposals, involving total investment of ₹39,436 crore, with a potential to generate over 1.11 lakh direct jobs. Among the proposals approved in the 16th meeting of the SIPB, chaired by Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu, in Amaravati on Tuesday were three companies in Amaravati Quantum Valley and other projects for utilising agriculture, horticulture and aquaculture waste to produce value-added byproducts. The Chief Minister directed officials to fully utilise the State's vast potential in solar power generation with

a special focus on developing the Rayalaseema region as a renewable energy hub. There was a need to attract largescale investments in solar energy projects, particularly in Rayalaseema districts, he said, while directing the officials to plan and develop robust transmission infrastructure.

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AXIS BANK

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We look forward to welcoming you.

QUICKLY.

Biocon launches 2 biosimilars in US

New Delhi: Biocon Ltd on Tuesday announced the commercial launch of biosimilars Bosaya and Aukelso, indicated for different serious bone conditions, in the US. Bosaya (biosimilar to Prolia) and Aukelso (biosimilar to Xgeva) are now available by prescription nationwide, as per a statement. Both products have been approved and granted interchangeable designation by the US Food and Drug Administration in September 2025. **PTI**

Novo Nordisk launches higher-dose Wegovy in US



Novo Nordisk said on Tuesday that it has made a higher-dose version of its weight-loss drug Wegovy available across the US. The 7.2-milligram dose, branded as Wegovy HD, gained approval under the FDA Commissioner's National Priority Review Voucher program last month. Before the approval, the highest authorised dose of injectable Wegovy for weight loss was 2.4 mg. The firm said higher-dose Wegovy will be available through US pharmacies, NovoCare Pharmacy and select telehealth providers. **REUTERS**

WhatsApp starts testing SIM-binding features

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

WhatsApp is testing out its SIM-linking features for limited users in preparation for the implementation of the provisions that have been extended till 2026.

Users on April 6 flagged an in-app notification that ask for SIM card verification for platform use on their device. The platform requests phone permission from users with the explanation, “Due to regulatory requirements in India, WhatsApp needs to check that your SIM card is in your device.” While the testing is not permanent, the move signals the platform’s readiness for implementation, as per sources.

Earlier, the government allowed messaging platforms an extension until December 31 to prepare for the SIM-binding obligations. However, industry sources told *businessline* that the De-

MeitY meets intermediaries to clarify on IT Rule amendments

WILLING TO LISTEN. Govt ‘open’ to suggestions; may extend April 14 feedback deadline

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Amidst backlash and criticism from the Internet societies and stakeholders about the amendments to the new Information Technology (IT) Rules, 2021, the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) on Tuesday met intermediaries and civil society groups with IT Secretary S Krishnan saying that the government is “open minded” and will examine all suggestions.

Krishnan indicated that the government may extend the April 14 deadline for receiving feedback on the proposed IT rules amendments and will consider industry and stakeholder views before finalising any changes.

On March 30, MeitY proposed amendments to the Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code Rules, 2021 (IT Rules, 2021) that significantly widen the government’s oversight over online content and expand the scope of entities that could face regulatory action.

The key change affecting individuals arises from amendments to Part III (Rule 8), which governs the applicability of Part III of the IT Rules, clarifies that over-



TIGHTENING POLICIES. MeitY Secretary indicated that the proposed changes are meant to bring user-generated news and current affairs content under clearer regulatory oversight

sight provisions extend to intermediaries hosting news and current affairs content posted by users who are not formally recognised as publishers.

After the stakeholders meeting, Krishnan said that questions that is very often raised with MeitY by intermediaries and stakeholders are: “What is that are we supposed to follow? Are we expected to follow guidance that the Ministry gives?” So MeitY is defining specific provision.

The Secretary indicated that the proposed changes are meant to bring user-generated news and current affairs content under clearer regulatory oversight, with the Ministry of Information and Broadcasting expected to play a central role in supervising such content even when it originates outside

formally registered media outlets.

“We are defining a specific provision which is under Section 79(2)(c) in terms of what should be the guidelines... then the changes are to Rule 3, Part 3 (of IT Rules), that is more related to the Ministry of Information and Broadcasting (MIB). Fundamentally, the MIB believes that according to the business rules, news and current affairs content is regulated by MIB... originally, the scope of what we were doing was with people who had registered news publishers. But, in today’s world, there is a lot more news which is done by users other than registered news publishers,” Krishnan said.

MAJOR CONCERN

Representatives from companies including Meta, Ins-

tagram, Google/YouTube, and industry bodies such as Nasscom attended the meeting, while in another meeting civil society groups such as MediaNama and the Internet Freedom Foundation attended, Krishnan informed.

The concerns from the Internet societies and stakeholders were that the draft rules effectively brings user-generated content of non-publisher users such as influencers and content creators under the same framework that currently applies to registered digital news publishers, expanding the scope of Part III of the rules.

There were concerns by these societies on the draft amendments such as no transparency or accountability in takedown/blocking actions and MeitY being not responsive to RTI requests. The current rules also do not have provisions for transparency, they said.

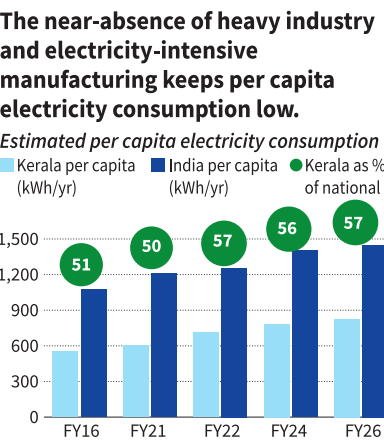
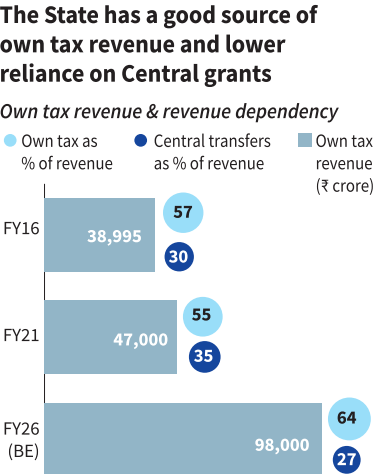
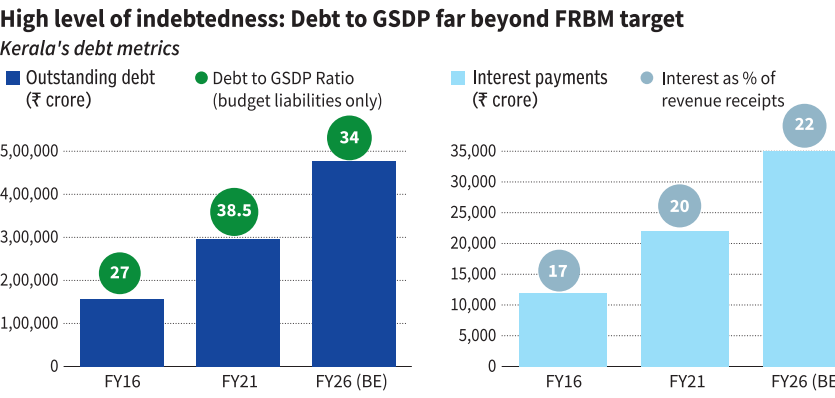
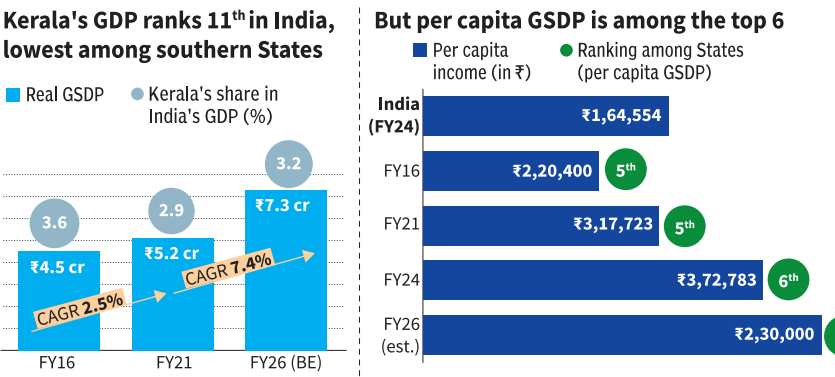
On asked about such concerns, Krishnan said, “We are neither going beyond what is contained in law, nor going beyond what is contained in the Constitution. We can’t go beyond that and we won’t go beyond that.” He added that MeitY was also ready to extend the deadline for public comments to the proposed amendments to the IT Rules, if need be.

VISUALLY.

Compiled by **Sourashis Banerjee** | Graphic: **Visveswaran V**

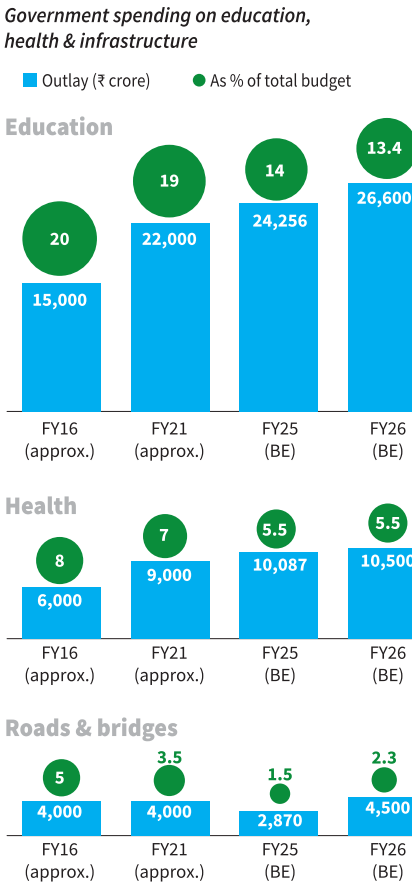
LDF: Losing the plot?

The Left Democratic Front (LDF) led by CM Pinarayi Vijayan, is aiming for something unprecedented since the formation of Kerala in 1956 — three consecutive Assembly wins. Standing at the precipice of history, the biggest hurdle for Vijayan is Kerala’s growth slowdown over the past decade. Despite strong social indicators, GSDP growth has been sluggish, lagging other southern States. This is due to Kerala’s GSDP being dominated by low-productivity services such as tourism and remittance-driven consumption, with limited expansion in high-growth sectors like IT or manufacturing. High committed expenses at 72 per cent of revenue receipts in FY26, limits the government’s ability to spend on capital formation, education or health. The State is having to borrow to meet the high revenue expenditure, leading to a large pile-up of debt. Given the current West Asia crisis, the dependence on remittances, which constitute approximately 16–20% of GSDP of Kerala, raises further questions for the government



Source: MoSPI, RBI State Finances, PRS Legislative Research, CAG Report 2023-24

Allocation to capex, education and health suffers due to high revenue expenditure



Centre extends reassessment of Vodafone-Idea’s AGR dues to June

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The Department of Telecommunications (DoT) has extended the deadline of adjusted gross revenue (AGR) reassessment for Vodafone-Idea (VIL) by three months to June, sources said on Tuesday.

The department expects that AGR reassessment for the company that recently received government relief for its dues and liabilities, will be completed by June. The reassessment was earlier targeted for completion by March 31.

Sources in the government said the review of spectrum usage charge (SUC) is on, following the internal licence fee reassessment by Controller of Communication Accounts. Accordingly, the timeline has been extended to June.

The Cabinet on December

31, 2025 had approved the relief to VIL based on the Supreme Court’s order and ‘frozen’ its AGR dues at ₹87,695 crore for a period ranging from FY06-07 to FY 18-19.

It also said the ‘frozen



Review of SUC is on, following the internal licence fee reassessment by Controller of Communication Accounts, say sources

dues are subject to reassessment.

The said amount excludes those AGR dues of FY17–18 and FY18–19, which stand finalised by the apex court’s 2020 order and payable in accordance.

DoT PANEL

A Committee constituted by DoT on January 30 this year, will decide on the outcome of such reassessment by the DoT.

“The Committee comprises a retired Secretary-level officer of Government of India and a representative of the Comptroller and Auditor General of India (CAG), as nominated by the CAG. The Committee shall finalise the outcome of the reassessment within a period of two months, unless extended,” Pemasani Chandra Sekhar, Minister of State for Communications, had said in reply to Lok Sabha questions last month.

Health-first indulgence, early onset of heat fuel summer surge for ice cream start-ups

Jyoti Banthia
Bengaluru

India’s ice cream brands are riding an unusual double tailwind this summer, an early onset of heat and a consumer base that is actively trading up to healthier, premium frozen desserts.

From protein-packed scoops to zero-sugar tubs, the guilt-free segment is no longer a fringe play. It is fast becoming a meaningful slice of the freezer aisle, with start-ups and legacy brands alike recalibrating their summer playbooks around it.

The shift is showing up most sharply on quick commerce platforms, where ice cream has found an unlikely spiritual home. Impulse-driven, instant-gratification-seeking, and heat-sensitive, the category is near-perfectly suited to 10-minute delivery. NOTO Founder Varun Sheth said the numbers bear this out. “Ice cream sales on quick commerce platforms have grown between 70 per cent and 100 per cent year-on-year,” he said, attributing the surge to both better distribution and stronger backend infrastructure. More tellingly, Sheth estimates that nearly 20 per cent of quick commerce ice



GUILT-FREE VERSIONS. Even basic flavours like vanilla and chocolate are now being reimaged as sugar-free variants

cream sales are now coming from the guilt-free segment. “What was a very small category two years ago is now being taken seriously by both start-ups and legacy players.

Even basic flavours like vanilla and chocolate are now being reimaged as sugar-free variants,” he said.

DISTRIBUTION ENGINE

Get-A-Way Co-Founder and CEO Jash Shah framed quick commerce as nothing short of a structural reset for challenger brands. “What used to be a 10-year distribution goal can now be fast-tracked within a couple of years,” he said.

“Consumers no longer need to store products; they can buy and consume instantly,” Shah added that the category is growing two to

bite-sized mini format launched specifically for impulse consumption.

Quick commerce sales has more than doubled for the brand over the past year and now contributes 6–7 per cent of revenues. “Consumer preferences are evolving, but indulgence remains at the heart of the category,” said Arvind Ramachandran, Vice-President of Marketing at Dairy Day. “Consumers are increasingly seeking variety within a single pack, contrast in flavours, and a change in texture with every bite — rather than plain single-flavoured offerings.”

Naturals Ice Cream is projecting 25–30 per cent y-o-y growth and is leaning into premiumisation and experimentation to get there, including a Dark Chocolate Sorbet and two collaborative flavours with Bombay Sweet Shop: Tender Coconut Naga Chilli and Coffee Almond Fudge. “We are seeing consumers gravitate towards unique and experimental flavour profiles,” said Director Siddhant Kamath. The brand is approaching quick commerce expansion carefully, given the low shelf life of its products, prioritising supply chain robustness before a broader rollout across major cities this financial year.

‘India’s biotech growth hinges on policy, funding reforms’

Aishwarya Kumar
Bengaluru

Kiran Mazumdar-Shaw, Executive Chairperson, Biocon Ltd, has flagged structural gaps in India’s biotech ecosystem, warning that weak venture funding, regulatory bottlenecks, and the absence of viable exit avenues are pushing high-value innovation out of the country.

Speaking about the sector’s evolution, Mazumdar-Shaw said India continues to face challenges in supporting clinical-stage innovation, a phase where companies are typically pre-revenue but require sustained capital. The long development cycle from lab to market, she noted, makes it harder to attract investors without well-defined pathways for exits.

She pointed to the need for deeper venture capital participation, more enabling listing frameworks, and regulatory clarity to support innovation at scale.

In more mature markets such as the US, clinical-stage biotech firms are able to access capital markets earlier, creating liquidity for investors and supporting long-term research.

China, too, has emerged as a significant pharmaceutical

“There is a need to strengthen the ecosystem through better access to risk capital, clearer regulatory frameworks and viable exit mechanisms. If we can create the right ecosystem, innovation itself can become an enormous value driver for India



KIRAN MAZUMDAR-SHAW
Executive Chairperson, Biocon Ltd

innovator, accounting for roughly 20–25 per cent of new drug research and development and about 46 per cent of novel molecules entering human trials in early 2025, according to a Goldman Sachs report, supported by strong state backing and faster clinical execution.

INDIA AT RISK

The consequence, she said, is a steady migration of innovation. Citing examples, Shaw highlighted how India-developed science is increasingly being commercialised overseas to tap better funding ecosystems and market

recognition. However, Shaw said individual company success cannot substitute for systemic reform. Without regulatory changes that enable risk capital, streamline regulatory pathways, and create credible exit mechanisms, India risks missing out on building a globally competitive biotech innovation engine.

“If we create the right ecosystem, innovation itself can become an enormous value driver for India,” she said, underlining that the country has no shortage of scientific capability, only enabling environment to fully realise it.

25 firms attend rare earth magnet pre-bid meet

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

The Centre’s push to build a domestic rare earth magnet ecosystem gathered momentum on Tuesday, with at least 25 companies, including JSW Group and NLC India, participating in a pre-bid conference for the ₹7,280-crore incentive scheme, sources said.

The pre-bid meeting, organised by the Ministry of Heavy Industries (MHI), is part of the government’s plan to build domestic capacity for sintered rare earth permanent magnets, a critical input for electric vehicles, wind turbines, electronics and defence systems.

While the bidding date is May 28, technical bids will be opened on May 29, 2026, with selected players getting a two-year window to set up facilities, followed by a five-year incentive period.

India currently holds nearly 8 per cent of global rare earth reserves but contributes less than 1 per cent to production. To support the push, the Budget 2026–27 has proposed dedicated rare earth corridors. The program seeks to create 6,000 mtpa of integrated manufacturing capacity, with up to five firms to be selected.

